

SAL-01 · SALARY AND SKILLS REPORT

Salary and skills report — framework and methodology

The measurement rules that decide whether a number is fit to
publish

VERSION 1.0 · DRAFT
2026-08-04

PROJECT CONTROLS INSTITUTE GLOBAL, INC.
AI proposes. The professional disposes.

— Summary

This document sets out how the Institute will measure reward and skills in project controls: what the survey asks, who it asks, how bias is mitigated, the minimum number of responses a cell must contain before any figure is published, how outliers and currencies are handled, and what the report will never claim. It contains no salary figures, because the survey has not been run. The methodology is published first so that the numbers, when they exist, can be checked against the rules that produced them.

— About this document

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Examples. All worked examples are illustrative and fictional. Figures are chosen to demonstrate a method, not to describe any real project, organisation or market. Sample examination items, where they appear, are study material maintained separately from any live examination bank.

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Contents

1. What practitioners are currently forced to use	4
2. Why this edition contains no numbers	4
3. What the report measures	5
4. Sampling frame and recruitment	5
5. Self-selection and the other biases we can name	6
6. The publication threshold — minimum cell size and suppression	6
7. Weighting — the method, and why the first cycle will not use it	7
8. Outliers, validation and unit errors	8
9. Currency, conversion and the purchasing-power caveat	8
10. Disclosure — what accompanies every figure	8
11. Publication rules and governance	9
12. Anti-goals — what this report will never claim	9
13. How this goes wrong	10
14. Worked example — the arithmetic, stated symbolically	10
15. Checklist — the pre-publication gate	11
Related	11
Sources and standards	11
Status and version	12

Salary and skills report — framework and methodology

In one paragraph. This document sets out how the Institute will measure reward and skills in project controls: what the survey asks, who it asks, how bias is mitigated, the minimum number of responses a cell must contain before any figure is published, how outliers and currencies are handled, and what the report will never claim. It contains no salary figures, because the survey has not been run. The methodology is published first so that the numbers, when they exist, can be checked against the rules that produced them.

Who this is for. Project controls managers and heads of function who are asked to justify a pay position; human resources and reward specialists who buy or build benchmark data; and researchers or subject-matter experts who will review, run or criticise the Institute's survey.

— 1. What practitioners are currently forced to use

Ask a planner what their role pays and the honest answer is a stack of things that are not measurements. A recruiter's verbal range, which is a negotiating position. A job advert, which is an offer to a market and not a record of what anyone was paid. A colleague's disclosure, which is one observation with no context. A published "salary guide" that names no sample, no definition of the role, no reference date and no method — and which, on inspection, is often a summary of the publisher's own placements or of scraped advertisements.

Each fails in the same specific way: it reports a number without reporting what the number is a number of. A figure attached to the word "planner" is meaningless until you know whether that planner carries a portfolio or a single package, works on a rotation or from home, is paid a base salary or a day rate, in what currency, gross or net, and in which year. Project controls professionals would reject a cost report built to that standard in a heartbeat. Market data deserves the standard we hold our own reporting to.

— 2. Why this edition contains no numbers

The Institute has not run the survey. Therefore this series publishes the instrument, the taxonomy, the publication rules and the report shell — and no figures at all.

This is a deliberate sequence, not a gap waiting to be filled quietly. Three reasons.

First, a number you cannot defend is worse than silence. A published figure travels: into pay reviews, into business cases, into other people's articles, and eventually back to us stripped of its caveats. Once it is loose, the caveat cannot catch it. The only point at which we control that is before publication.

Second, publishing the method first is a falsifiable commitment. Anyone can write a methodology appendix after the data is in, tuned to justify what the data happened to say. A methodology

published before fielding can be checked against the report that follows it: if the minimum cell size in §6 is relaxed for one attractive table, that is visible. We are making it easy to catch ourselves.

Third, it is the discipline we certify. A controls professional who reports an estimate at completion (EAC) they cannot substantiate has failed at the core of the job. A professional body that publishes a methodology before it publishes a number is demonstrating, at its own cost, the behaviour it examines candidates on. If we were willing to invent a salary range for the sake of a press cycle, no reader should trust anything else we publish.

This is not an apology for an absence. Everything needed to run an honest annual report is here: a fielded instrument (SAL-02), a role taxonomy and levelling rubric that makes comparison possible (SAL-03), a skills vocabulary (SAL-04), and a report template whose tables are structurally complete and empty (SAL-05). The missing element is field data, and field data is the one thing that cannot be written at a desk.

— 3. What the report measures

Unit of analysis. One individual, in one role, over one defined reference period. Not a job, not a vacancy, not an employer's grade.

Reference period. A single stated period — the twelve months ending on a declared reference date — so that every respondent answers about the same window
[CONFIRM: fielding window and reference date for the first cycle — to be set by the Institute's research lead].

In scope: individuals whose substantive work is project controls as defined by the role taxonomy in SAL-03, in any sector and any country, employed or self-employed, whether or not they hold any certification.

Out of scope: aspirational or advertised pay; pay for roles the respondent no longer holds outside the reference period; employer-level pay policy; equity in privately held companies where no defensible valuation exists; and any figure the respondent is contractually barred from disclosing.

Remuneration is decomposed, never asked as one number. Base pay, fixed allowances, variable pay, overtime, day rate and employer retirement contributions are separate questions with separate bases. This is the single most common defect in market pay data: one respondent reports base, the next reports total cash, and the resulting "median" is a summary of two different quantities. SAL-02 §7 specifies the decomposition and the wording.

— 4. Sampling frame and recruitment

There is no register of the world's project controls professionals. That is a fact about the profession, not a difficulty to be papered over, and it constrains everything downstream.

The frame is therefore constructed, not enumerated. Recruitment runs through the Institute's own channels (members, candidates, newsletter subscribers), professional social networks, employer and consultancy contacts who agree to circulate the link without seeing responses, and open publication of the survey URL so that participation does not require any relationship with the Institute.

This produces a non-probability, volunteer sample. No sample size converts a volunteer sample into a probability sample. The report will say so on the same page as its first table, in those

words, every year. What we can do is characterise the sample precisely, mitigate the biases we can name, and refuse to publish where the sample is too thin to bear a claim.

Open participation is a deliberate control. If only members could respond, the sample would be a study of PCI members' pay reported as a study of the profession. Membership and certification status are recorded as respondent characteristics — never as eligibility.

— 5. Self-selection and the other biases we can name

Bias	How it enters	Mitigation
Self-selection	People with an unusual position — very well or very badly paid — have more reason to answer	Recruit through channels with no reward angle; keep the questionnaire short enough that indifferent respondents finish; publish composition against every characteristic collected
Seniority skew	Senior practitioners are more visible and more often reached	Report every cut by level; never present an all-respondent figure as "the profession"; disclose the level distribution beside every headline
Geographic and language skew	Recruitment travels furthest in the languages and networks we already occupy	Translate the instrument [CONFIRM: translation languages for the first cycle] (see SAL-02 §12); suppress regions below threshold rather than merging them into a flattering aggregate
Non-response within the instrument	Pay questions are abandoned more often than any other	"Prefer not to say" on every remuneration question, so a respondent can skip one figure without abandoning the survey; report item-level response counts, not just the overall count
Anchoring	Showing a figure in the questionnaire moves the answers towards it	No figure, band or "typical" value appears anywhere in the instrument before the respondent's own answer
Social desirability	Reported skills drift upward; reported dissatisfaction drifts downward	Skills are asked against behavioural anchors (SAL-04), not adjectives; satisfaction items are separated from identity items
Survivorship	People who left the profession are absent by construction	Stated as a limitation; the report never infers anything about retention or attrition

Two of these deserve emphasis because they are the ones that quietly destroy a pay survey. **Anchoring** is why the instrument shows nothing. **Composition** is why every table carries its own denominator: a "median for cost engineers" computed from a sample that happens to be four-fifths one region is a regional figure wearing a global label.

— 6. The publication threshold — minimum cell size and suppression

A cell is any combination of reporting dimensions for which a figure might be published: role × level, role × level × region, sector × contract type, and so on. The rules below are absolute. They are applied by the analyst before anyone sees the output, and they are not waived for a table someone wants.

#	Rule	Test	Consequence
1	Minimum cell size	Fewer than 30 valid responses in the cell	No statistic of any kind is published for that cell. Not a median, not a range, not an "indicative" figure, not a sentence describing it in words
2	Distribution detail	30 or more but fewer than 100 responses	Median and quartiles only. No deciles, no minimum, no maximum, no tail commentary
3	Employer dominance	One employer contributes more than a quarter of the cell, or the three largest contribute more than half	Cell suppressed. A figure that is really one organisation's pay policy is not a market figure
4	Complementary suppression	A suppressed cell can be recovered by subtracting published cells from a published total	A second cell is suppressed so the first cannot be reconstructed
5	Aggregation discipline	A thin cell is combined with another to reach the threshold	Permitted only along the pre-declared hierarchy in SAL-03 §6, and the combined cell is labelled as combined
6	Comparison across cycles	Both cycles meet rules 1–3 on the same definition, and the relevant question wording was unchanged	Otherwise no year-on-year statement is made, in figures or in prose
7	Denominator disclosure	Every table, chart and sentence containing a figure	Carries its unweighted response count
8	Suppression log	Every cell suppressed under rules 1–4	Listed in an annex with the rule invoked, so suppression cannot be applied selectively to shape a story

Rule 1 has one property worth stating plainly: **it will suppress the cuts people most want.** Niche roles in smaller markets are exactly where individual practitioners have least information and most need it, and exactly where the sample will be thinnest. We will not fill that gap with a number we cannot stand behind. The honest output is a visible hole with a stated reason, and an invitation to help the next cycle reach the threshold.

— 7. Weighting — the method, and why the first cycle will not use it

Post-stratification corrects a sample whose composition differs from a known population. For stratum h , the weight is the population share divided by the sample share:

$$w_h = (N_h \div N) \div (n_h \div n)$$

where N_h is the population count in stratum h , N the population total, n_h the responses in stratum h , and n the total responses. Weights are trimmed at bounds declared before weighting is applied, because a single respondent carrying an enormous weight is a single respondent. Precision after weighting is reported through the effective sample size (the Kish formula), never through the raw count, which overstates what the weighted estimate can support.

The method requires N_h , and we do not have it. No authoritative population distribution of project controls professionals by role, level, sector and region is known to the Institute [\[CONFIRM: whether any nameable, dated population distribution exists that could serve as a weighting frame; weighting is not applied without one\]](#). Weighting to a guessed population is worse than not weighting, because it converts a visible composition problem into an invisible one and attaches a scientific-sounding label to it.

Accordingly: **the first cycle is reported unweighted, with full composition disclosed.** If a defensible frame becomes available, weighting will be introduced as a clearly labelled addition, both weighted and unweighted results will be published side by side for the first cycle in which it applies, and the frame will be named and dated in the report.

— 8. Outliers, validation and unit errors

Three different problems get called "outliers", and conflating them is how good data gets deleted.

Entry errors are wrong values: a monthly amount typed into an annual field, a currency selected incorrectly, a digit added. They are detected by ratio and plausibility checks against bounds set per currency and basis before fielding and recorded in the fielding log. A record is corrected only where the intended value is unambiguous from the rest of the response; otherwise the affected item — not the whole response — is excluded.

Ineligible responses fail a screening rule, duplicate one respondent, or show patterns inconsistent with genuine completion: a straight-lined matrix, or a completion time below a pre-set floor. These are removed and counted.

Genuine extremes are real values far from the centre. The rule for handling them — exclusion above a stated distance from the quartiles, winsorising to a stated percentile, or retention — is declared before the data is examined and applied identically to every cell, never chosen after seeing which choice produces the tidier result.

Three disclosure rules apply to all three: the count of records affected is published; nothing is removed silently; and no record is ever removed because it makes a series less smooth.

— 9. Currency, conversion and the purchasing-power caveat

Respondents answer in the currency they are paid in, and state the basis (gross or net, annual, monthly, daily or hourly). Nothing is converted at the point of entry.

For reporting, amounts are converted to a single base currency at a single reference date using a named, published rate source [\[CONFIRM: foreign-exchange rate source and the single reference date used for conversion\]](#). One date for the whole dataset, disclosed, so that conversion is a stated transformation rather than a moving target.

The caveat that must travel with every converted figure: **conversion compares nominal amounts, not living standards.** A converted figure says nothing about what the money buys, about tax and social contributions, about mandatory retirement contributions, about employer-provided healthcare, or about which of those a jurisdiction treats as pay at all. Employment, tax and pay-transparency law differ by country, and the report will not present any one country's treatment as the general case. A purchasing-power adjustment, if published, is a separate and separately labelled table using a named index [\[CONFIRM: whether a purchasing-power adjustment is published for the first cycle, and which named index would be used\]](#) — never silently folded into the headline.

— 10. Disclosure — what accompanies every figure

Every figure the report publishes is accompanied by six things, without exception: the definition of the population it describes; the unweighted response count; the reference period; the remunera-

tion component it measures; the currency and basis; and the rule under which any neighbouring cell was suppressed. A figure lacking any of the six is not published, and a figure quoted onward without them has been misquoted — which is the subject of [SAL-06](#).

The instrument, the role taxonomy, the skills codebook and the suppression log are published as annexes in every edition, so a reader can reconstruct what was asked and reproduce the coding decisions.

— 11. Publication rules and governance

Three rules bind the report's production.

No commercial influence over content. No sponsor, advertiser, employer or recruitment business sees results before publication, chooses which cuts are published, or has any role in the methodology. Where a partner circulates the survey, that is disclosed and confers nothing else.

No individual or employer identification. Free-text answers are screened for identifying detail before coding, and that detail is removed rather than paraphrased. No employer is named in any output. Personal data handling is governed by the consent and privacy provisions in [SAL-02 §2 \[CON-FIRM: data controller, lawful basis, retention period and erasure procedure — pending legal review, see SAL-02 §2\]](#).

Corrections are public. If a published figure is wrong, the correction is posted to the channels that carried the original, with a dated note in the report itself. A quietly replaced file is a second error on top of the first.

— 12. Anti-goals — what this report will never claim

Stated as prohibitions, so that a future edition drifting towards any of them is visibly in breach.

1. It will never claim to state the market rate, the going rate, or what a role "should" pay. It reports what a defined set of respondents said they received.
2. It will never claim that holding a PCI credential — or any credential — causes a pay outcome. The Institute makes no claim of guaranteed employment or salary outcomes, and a cross-sectional survey cannot establish causation in either direction.
3. It will never publish a figure for a cell below the threshold in §6, however often it is requested.
4. It will never present advertised pay as paid pay, or blend advertisement data into survey results.
5. It will never forecast pay, or describe a movement between two cycles as a trend.
6. It will never present one jurisdiction's employment, tax or pay-transparency law as universal.
7. It will never publish anything from which an individual or an employer can be identified.
8. It will never restate a prior cycle's figure after a definition change without labelling the break.
9. It will never be sold, licensed or presented as a job-matching or pay-setting service for an individual.
10. It will never imply accreditation, endorsement or recognition the Institute does not hold.

— 13. How this goes wrong

The seniority spiral. Year one skews senior; the headline figure is high; the survey acquires a reputation as the place where well-paid people report; year two skews further. The defence is refusing to publish an all-respondent headline at all, and reporting only within level.

The title trap. Respondents self-classify by their employer's title, and "senior planner" at one company is "planning manager" at another. Left alone, this produces cells that are internally incoherent. SAL-03 exists to break it: respondents are classified by accountability and autonomy, with the title recorded separately as free text.

The single-employer cell. A large organisation circulates the survey enthusiastically, and a regional cell becomes that organisation's pay bands with a market label on it. Rule 3 in §6 catches it — but only if employer is collected at a level that makes the test possible, which is why SAL-02 asks for employer type and, optionally, an employer identifier used solely for this test and never reported.

The silent definition change. A question is improved between cycles, and the improved series is compared with the old one because both are called "base pay". Rule 6 forbids it; the change log in SAL-05 makes the breach visible.

The press-release cut. Someone finds the one comparison that makes a headline, and it is published without its denominator — or a thin cell is merged upward until it clears the threshold and is then discussed as though it were the original. The rules that every figure carries its response count, and that combination follows a declared hierarchy, exist precisely for the moment when they are inconvenient.

— 14. Worked example — the arithmetic, stated symbolically

No illustrative figures are used in this series, by design. Elsewhere in the Institute's publication programme numeric worked examples are the backbone of the teaching. Here they would be a hazard: an invented respondent distribution, however clearly labelled, is exactly the kind of number that gets screenshotted without its label. So the arithmetic is shown in symbols only.

Post-stratification weight for stratum h , with population and sample counts as defined in §7:

$$w_h = (N_h \div N) \div (n_h \div n)$$

Read it as: a stratum that is under-represented in the sample relative to the population receives a weight above one, and vice versa. Applied to the first cycle, the expression is undefined, because N_h has no value we can name. That is the whole argument of §7 in one line.

Effective sample size for a weighted estimate, over respondents i with weights w_i :

$$n_{\text{eff}} = (\sum w_i)^2 \div \sum (w_i^2)$$

Read it as: the more unequal the weights, the fewer independent observations the estimate is really worth. When weighting is used, precision claims are made against n_{eff} , never against the raw count.

The suppression test for a cell c with response count n_c and largest-employer share s_c : publish only if $n_c \geq 30$ **and** $s_c \leq \frac{1}{4}$ **and** the sum of the three largest employer shares $\leq \frac{1}{2}$. All three conditions, not any of them.

— 15. Checklist — the pre-publication gate

Run before any edition of the report is released. Any unticked line stops publication of the affected table, not of the report.

- ☐ Every published cell meets the minimum response count in §6, rule 1
- ☐ Employer-dominance test run on every published cell, and its result recorded
- ☐ Complementary suppression applied where a suppressed cell is recoverable by subtraction
- ☐ Suppression log complete, with the rule invoked for each suppressed cell
- ☐ Every table, chart and figure-bearing sentence carries its unweighted response count
- ☐ Currency, basis, reference period and remuneration component stated for every figure
- ☐ Conversion source and reference date stated; no purchasing-power claim without a named index
- ☐ Outlier and exclusion rules were declared before the data was examined, and the affected counts published
- ☐ No year-on-year statement without both cycles meeting the threshold on unchanged wording
- ☐ Composition annex published against every respondent characteristic collected
- ☐ Instrument, taxonomy and codebook published as annexes
- ☐ Anti-goals in §12 re-read against the final draft, including the headline and the social posts
- ☐ No sponsor or partner has seen results before publication
- ☐ Free text screened for identifying detail before coding

— Related

- [SAL-02 – The survey instrument](#) — the questionnaire this methodology governs, question by question
- [SAL-03 – Role taxonomy and levelling](#) — the classification that makes any cross-employer comparison possible
- [SAL-05 – Report template and data tables](#) — the empty shell these rules will fill
- [SAL-06 – Using market data honestly](#) — the reader-facing companion, including how to read a median
- [EXB-06 – Job-task analysis: where the blueprint gets its authority](#) — the same evidential discipline applied to the examination

— Sources and standards

No external market source is cited, because none has been consulted and none would be cited without consultation. The internal artefacts this document depends on are the Institute's canonical facts register ([docs/publication-framework/00-framework/CANONICAL-FACTS.md](#)), the editorial standard

governing evidence and claims ([00-framework/EDITORIAL-STANDARD.md](#) §4), and the unverified-fact rule in the framework README §4. Statistical methods named in §7 and §14 — post-stratification, weight trimming, the Kish effective sample size, winsorising — are standard survey-methodology techniques described here in our own words; the report's methodology annex will cite the specific texts relied on once the research lead has selected them.

— Status and version

Founding-stage document · Version 1.0 · draft · Reviewed under PCI governance. PCI makes no claims of accreditation or recognition beyond what is true today.

SAL-02 · SALARY AND SKILLS REPORT

The survey instrument

The questionnaire, question by question, ready to field



VERSION 1.0 · DRAFT

2026-08-04

PROJECT CONTROLS INSTITUTE GLOBAL, INC.

AI proposes. The professional disposes.

— Summary

The complete questionnaire for the Institute's salary and skills survey: consent and privacy wording, screening, role and level, employment context, contract type, experience and qualifications, the decomposed remuneration block, skills held against skills required, AI tool use, satisfaction and mobility. Every question carries its wording, its answer options, its routing and a note on why it is worded that way. No figure, band or example value appears anywhere in the instrument, because showing one would move the answers.

— About this document

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Contents

1. How to use this instrument.....	4
2. Block A — consent, privacy and data handling.....	4
3. Block B — screening	5
4. Block C — role and level.....	6
5. Block D — employment and project context.....	7
6. Block E — contract type and working pattern.....	8
7. Block F — experience, qualifications and certification.....	8
8. Block G — remuneration, asked component by component.....	9
For employees (routed from Q18).....	9
For day-rate and self-employed respondents (routed from Q18).....	10
9. Block H — skills held and skills required.....	11
10. Block I — AI in the work.....	11
11. Block J — satisfaction, mobility and transparency	12
12. Block K — free text and close	12
13. Routing map	13
14. Fielding notes.....	13
15. How this goes wrong.....	14
16. Checklist — before this instrument is fielded.....	14
Related	14
Sources and standards.....	15
Status and version	15

The survey instrument

In one paragraph. This is the complete questionnaire for the Institute's salary and skills survey: consent and privacy wording, screening, role and level, employment context, contract type, experience and qualifications, the decomposed remuneration block, skills held against skills required, AI tool use, satisfaction and mobility. Every question carries its wording, its answer options, its routing and a note on why it is worded that way. No figure, band or example value appears anywhere in the instrument, because showing one would move the answers.

Who this is for. The research lead and reviewers who will pilot, translate and field this survey; subject-matter experts asked to critique it before it goes live; and anyone building a comparable instrument who would rather start from something argued than from a blank page.

— 1. How to use this instrument

Field it as written, or change it and record the change. The questions are not interchangeable phrasings of a general idea: the wording, the option sets and the order have been chosen against the biases named in [SAL-01](#) §5, and a well-meaning edit can undo a control silently. Where a change is needed, it goes in the instrument change log carried in [SAL-05](#) §12, because a question that changed between cycles cannot be compared across them.

Notation used below.

Convention	Meaning
Q00	Question number, stable across cycles. Retired numbers are never reused
Type	single (one option), multi (several), numeric , text , scale , matrix
Routing	The condition under which the question is shown. Unconditional unless stated
Required	Whether the respondent may continue without answering
Note	Why the question is worded this way. Not shown to the respondent
A bracketed CONFIRM marker	Wording or a parameter that cannot be settled without a decision or a legal review

Three rules bind every question. No figure, band, average or "typical" value is ever shown to a respondent before they answer — anchoring is the fastest way to ruin a pay survey. Every remuneration question offers Prefer not to say, so a respondent who will not disclose one component does not abandon the whole response. And no question is mandatory except the screening and consent items, because a forced answer is a guessed answer.

— 2. Block A — consent, privacy and data handling

This block is shown first, on its own screen. The respondent cannot proceed without an affirmative action. The wording below is a drafting starting point and is **not cleared for use**: every bracketed

item requires legal review in the jurisdictions where the survey is fielded, and the Institute must not present one jurisdiction's data-protection regime as the general case.

Before you start

This survey is run by the Project Controls Institute. It asks about your role, your skills and how you are paid. It takes about fifteen minutes.

What we collect. Your answers, and technical information your browser sends. We do not ask for your name, your employer's name, or your address. If you choose to give us an email address at the end, it is stored separately from your answers.

Why we collect it. To produce an annual public report on reward and skills in project controls. The report contains statistics only. No individual and no employer is identified in anything we publish, and no figure is published for any group smaller than the threshold stated in our published methodology.

Who controls the data. [\[CONFIRM: named data controller entity, registered address and contact point for data-protection queries — pending legal review\]](#)

Our lawful basis. [\[CONFIRM: lawful basis for processing in each jurisdiction where the survey is fielded, and the wording used to describe it — pending legal review\]](#)

How long we keep it. [\[CONFIRM: retention period for individual responses and for the analysis dataset, and the deletion process at the end of it — pending legal review\]](#)

Where it is processed. [\[CONFIRM: survey platform and processor, hosting jurisdiction, and the mechanism relied on for any cross-border transfer — pending legal review\]](#)

Withdrawing. You can stop at any point and nothing is saved. After you submit, you can ask us to delete your response using the reference shown on the final screen [\[CONFIRM: withdrawal and erasure procedure, the window during which it is possible, and the point after which responses are irreversibly aggregated — pending legal review\]](#).

What you get. Nothing is required of you and nothing is sold to you. If you want the report when it is published, you can leave an email address at the end. [\[CONFIRM: whether any incentive or prize draw is offered, and if so its full terms, eligibility and the jurisdictions in which it may lawfully be run — pending legal review\]](#)

Q01 — Consent. Type: single. Required. "I have read the above and I am willing to take part." Options: [Yes, continue](#) · [No, exit](#). Routing: [No](#) ends the survey with a thank-you screen and no data retained. Note: an explicit affirmative action, not a pre-ticked box and not implied consent from proceeding. It is also the last screen on which a respondent can leave costlessly, which is why the commitment (about fifteen minutes) is stated above it rather than discovered halfway through.

— 3. Block B — screening

Q02 — Current involvement. Type: single. Required. "Which of these best describes your work in the twelve months to the reference date shown above?" Options: [I worked mainly in a project controls role](#) · [I worked in a role that included project controls among other duties](#) · [I manage or lead people who do project controls work](#) · [I work in project controls software, recruitment, training or consulting to the field, but not in a controls role myself](#) · [None of these](#). Routing: [None of these](#) and the software/recruitment/training option exit to a thank-you screen. Note: the fourth option exists to catch, and politely remove, the group most likely to be interested in a pay survey and least appropriate for it. Without it, those respondents pick the nearest fitting option and contaminate the sample.

Q03 — Country of work. Type: single, searchable list. Required. "In which country did you do most of your work during the period?" Note: country of work, not of residence, citizenship or em-

employer registration. Rotational and remote cross-border working makes these four different answers, and pay attaches to the work location far more often than to the other three.

Q04 — Cross-border working pattern. Type: single. "Did you work mainly in that country, or on a rotation or assignment away from your home country?" Options: [Mainly in that country, living there](#) · [Rotational or fly-in fly-out](#) · [On international assignment or secondment](#) · [Fully remote from another country](#) · [Prefer not to say](#). Note: rotation and expatriate assignment packages are structurally different from local pay and must be separable in analysis. Merging them produces cells that look like extreme local pay and are not.

Q05 — Reference period check. Type: single. Required. "Were you in paid work in this field for at least six months of the period?" Options: [Yes](#) · [No](#). Routing: [No](#) exits. Note: keeps the sample to people with a full enough period for the remuneration questions to mean something, and prevents part-period pay being reported as annual pay.

— 4. Block C — role and level

Q06 — Job title as written. Type: text. Required. "What is your job title, exactly as your employer writes it?" Note: free text captured verbatim and coded later against [SAL-03](#). It is asked before the taxonomy question so that the taxonomy options do not reshape the respondent's memory of their own title. It is never used as the classification variable — see [SAL-01](#) §13, "the title trap".

Q07 — Primary role. Type: single. Required. "Which of these best describes what you actually spend most of your time doing? Full definitions are in the linked role guide." Options: the ten canonical roles in [SAL-03](#) §3 — [Planner / scheduler](#) · [Cost engineer](#) · [Cost controller](#) · [Estimator](#) · [Risk analyst](#) · [Change / commercial controller](#) · [Reporting and data analyst](#) · [Project controls lead](#) · [Project controls manager](#) · [Head of project controls](#) — plus [Other project controls role \(please describe\)](#). Note: "what you actually spend most of your time doing" rather than "your role", because in small teams the title and the work diverge sharply. The definitions are linked rather than embedded so the question stays readable on a phone.

Q08 — Second role. Type: single, optional. "If your work is genuinely split between two of those, which is the second?" Note: combined planner-and-cost roles are common and must not be forced into one bucket. In analysis a respondent contributes to their primary role only; the second role is used to characterise the sample and to flag cells where combined roles dominate.

Q09 — Level, by behaviour. Type: single. Required. "Which of these describes your work best? Choose on what you are accountable for, not on your title." Options: the four levelling descriptors from [SAL-03](#) §4, presented in full sentences describing autonomy, the complexity of the work owned, and what the respondent's judgement is trusted with — labelled [Foundation](#) · [Practitioner](#) · [Professional](#) · [Leader](#). Note: the descriptors are behavioural because self-rated seniority is otherwise a measure of confidence. The labels match the Institute's competency levels ([CMP-02](#)), which is what allows the report to be read alongside the competency framework. Note that "professional" here is a level on a competency scale and is a different concept from the level at which the Institute's credentials sit.

Q10 — Reporting line. Type: single. "Who do you report to?" Options: [A project controls specialist](#) · [A project or programme manager](#) · [A commercial or finance manager](#) · [A functional or department head](#) · [A director or executive](#) · [A client representative](#) · [Other](#) · [Prefer not to say](#). Note: a levelling cross-check that respondents cannot easily inflate, and a genuinely interesting structural variable: whether controls reports into delivery or into finance changes the job.

Q11 — People responsibility. Type: single. "How many people report to you directly?" Options: None · 1–2 · 3–5 · 6–10 · 11–25 · More than 25 · Prefer not to say. Note: bands rather than a number, because exact headcount is identifying in small organisations and adds nothing.

Q12 — Scope owned. Type: single. "What do you have controls accountability for?" Options: Part of one project · One whole project · Several projects · A programme · A portfolio or business unit · A functional capability across the organisation · Prefer not to say. Note: the strongest single discriminator between levels, and far more comparable across employers than either title or headcount.

— 5. Block D — employment and project context

Q13 — Employer type. Type: single. Required. Options: Owner, operator or client organisation · Main contractor · Subcontractor or specialist contractor · Engineering or design consultancy · Project management or controls consultancy · Government body or public authority · Agency or umbrella company · Self-employed / own company · Other. Note: the side of the table a person sits on is one of the largest structural influences on how a controls role is paid, and it is knowable without asking for pay.

Q14 — Employer identifier. Type: text, optional. "Optionally, your employer's name. It is used only to check that no published figure is dominated by one organisation, and is deleted before analysis. It is never published and never reported back." Note: this exists solely to make the employer-dominance test in SAL-01 §6 rule 3 possible. It is optional, its single purpose is stated, and the field is hashed on receipt and the plain text discarded. A survey that cannot run the dominance test cannot detect its worst failure mode. Where a respondent declines, the record counts towards the cell size but is treated as unknown-employer in the test.

Q15 — Sector. Type: single. Required. Options: Oil, gas and petrochemical · Power and utilities · Renewables · Nuclear · Mining and metals · Transport and rail infrastructure · Water · Buildings and property · Manufacturing and industrial · Pharmaceutical and life sciences · Technology and digital · Defence and aerospace · Public sector programmes · Financial services change · Other. Note: one list, cross-industry, deliberately not weighted towards the sectors project controls historically came from. Financial services change and Technology and digital are included because controls work exists there and is systematically missing from surveys built around heavy industry.

Q16 — Typical project or portfolio size. Type: single. "What is the approximate capital value of the project or portfolio you work on?" Options: [CONFIRM: capital value bands — to be defined once, in a stated currency with a stated conversion basis, and held constant across cycles so the variable is comparable] plus Don't know · Prefer not to say. Note: deliberately left unset here. Bands must be defined once, published, and never adjusted quietly, because changing them breaks comparability while looking like a cosmetic edit.

Q17 — Contract environment. Type: multi. Options: Lump sum / fixed price · Reimbursable · Target cost with pain-gain · Framework or call-off · Alliance or integrated delivery · Public-private partnership or concession · Don't know. Note: multi-select because most people work across several. It is asked because commercial model changes what a controls role has to do, which is context the skills block needs.

— 6. Block E — contract type and working pattern

Q18 — Engagement type. Type: single. Required. Options: [Permanent employee](#) · [Fixed-term employee](#) · [Day-rate contractor through my own company](#) · [Day-rate contractor through an umbrella company](#) · [Agency worker](#) · [Self-employed / sole trader](#) · [Seconded from another organisation](#) · [Other](#). Routing: drives the remuneration block. Employees route to Q26–Q31; day-rate and self-employed respondents route to Q32–Q35. Note: this is the most consequential routing question in the instrument. Asking a contractor for an annual salary, or an employee for a day rate, produces answers that are converted by the respondent using assumptions we never see. Each is asked in its own terms and reported separately, never merged.

Q19 — Working time. Type: single. Required. Options: [Full time](#) · [Part time](#) · [Rotational cycle](#) · [Varies](#). Routing: [Part time](#) shows Q20.

Q20 — Part-time proportion. Type: single. Routing: Q19 = Part time. Options: [Up to a quarter of full time](#) · [About half](#) · [About three-quarters](#) · [Other](#) · [Prefer not to say](#). Note: proportions, not hours, because contractual full-time hours differ by country and industry. Part-time pay is reported only on a stated full-time-equivalent (FTE) basis, and the basis is disclosed.

Q21 — Work location pattern. Type: single. Options: [Fully on site or in the office](#) · [Mostly on site, some remote](#) · [Balanced hybrid](#) · [Mostly remote](#) · [Fully remote](#) · [Rotational camp or offshore](#). Note: a structural characteristic, asked without any implication that one pattern should pay more.

— 7. Block F — experience, qualifications and certification

Q22 — Total experience. Type: single. Required. "How long have you worked in project controls or a closely related discipline?" Options: [Less than 2 years](#) · [2–4 years](#) · [5–9 years](#) · [10–14 years](#) · [15–19 years](#) · [20–29 years](#) · [30 years or more](#). Note: bands, because recalled exact tenure is spuriously precise. The bands are uneven on purpose: they are narrow where careers change fastest and wide where they do not.

Q23 — Time in current role. Type: single. Options: [Less than 1 year](#) · [1–2 years](#) · [3–5 years](#) · [6–10 years](#) · [More than 10 years](#).

Q24 — Highest completed qualification. Type: single. Options: [Secondary education](#) · [Vocational or technical qualification](#) · [Apprenticeship](#) · [Undergraduate degree](#) · [Postgraduate degree](#) · [Doctorate](#) · [Prefer not to say](#). Note: one neutral ladder, with no implication that any level is expected. The Institute's own eligibility rule requires three years of professional experience in any field and no degree, and the instrument must not contradict that in its framing.

Q25 — Certifications held. Type: multi. "Which professional certifications do you currently hold?" Options: [PCI PCL-AI](#) · [PCI PFL-AI](#) · [PCI PML-AI](#) · [PCI AIPC \(AI in Project Controls – Specialist Certificate\)](#) · [A certification from another professional body \(please name\)](#) · [A vendor or software certification \(please name\)](#) · [None](#) · [Prefer not to say](#). Note: two things matter here. Other bodies' certifications are captured by free text rather than a curated list, so the instrument neither endorses nor omits anyone. And this question is about certification; membership is asked separately at Q26, because a membership grade and a credential are different ladders and conflating them is a category error the Institute is careful never to make.

Q26 — Membership. Type: multi. "Are you a member of any professional body? Membership is separate from certification." Options: [Yes, of PCI](#) · [Yes, of another body \(please name\)](#) · [No](#) · [Prefer not to say](#).

— 8. Block G — remuneration, asked component by component

The whole block is preceded by one instruction screen:

The next questions ask about pay. Please answer for the twelve months to the reference date, in the currency you are paid in, **before tax and any deductions**, and answer each component separately — we will not add them up for you incorrectly. Every question here can be skipped.

Q27 — Currency. Type: single, searchable. Required for the block. "Which currency are you paid in?" Note: asked before any amount, so the respondent enters a number in a field already labelled with their own currency. Nothing is converted at entry; conversion happens once, centrally, at a single reference date (SAL-01 §9).

Q28 — Basis. Type: single. Required for the block. "Are the amounts you are about to give gross (before tax) or net (after tax)?" Options: [Gross](#) · [Net](#) · [Not sure](#). Note: a survey that assumes gross will silently mix in net answers from countries where net is the number people know. Analysis uses gross only; net answers are reported as a separate count and excluded from pay statistics rather than converted, because converting requires modelling a jurisdiction's tax and we do not do that.

For employees (routed from Q18)

Q29 — Base pay. Type: numeric, with a period selector. Optional. "What is your annual base salary, excluding all allowances, bonus and overtime?" Period selector: [per year](#) · [per month](#) · [per week](#) · [per hour](#). Note: the period selector is essential. Forcing annualisation makes the respondent do arithmetic we cannot inspect, and it is the largest single source of unit errors (SAL-01 §8). The exclusions are listed inside the question rather than in a footnote, because footnotes are not read.

Q30 — Fixed allowances. Type: multi with amounts, optional. "Do you receive any fixed allowances on top of base pay? Give the annual value of each you receive." Categories: [Site or location allowance](#) · [Rotation or offshore allowance](#) · [Housing](#) · [Transport or car](#) · [Travel or subsistence paid regardless of travel](#) · [Cost-of-living or hardship allowance](#) · [Other fixed allowance](#). Note: allowances are where international and rotational pay actually lives, and where they are lumped into "salary" the resulting comparison between a site-based and an office-based respondent is non-sense. Each is captured separately so the report can state exactly which components a figure includes.

Q31 — Variable pay. Type: numeric ×2, optional. "If you have a bonus or incentive scheme: what is your target or on-target amount, and what were you actually paid for the last completed period?" Two fields: [Target](#) · [Actually paid](#). Plus [I have no bonus scheme](#) · [I have one but received nothing](#) · [Prefer not to say](#). Note: target and actual are asked separately because they diverge, and because a survey that asks only one gets whichever one flatters the respondent. "Received nothing" is a distinct answer from "no scheme" and from a skip; collapsing the three is how bonus data becomes uninterpretable.

Q32 — Overtime and additional hours. Type: single plus optional numeric. "Are you paid for hours beyond your contracted hours?" Options: [No, my pay covers all hours worked](#) · [Yes, at plain time](#) · [Yes, at an enhanced rate](#) · [Yes, through time off in lieu only](#) · [Prefer not to say](#); if paid, an optional annual amount. Note: in several sectors overtime is a large and routine part of controls pay, and in others it does not exist. A total-cash figure that silently includes it in one cell and excludes it in another is not a comparison.

Q33 — Employer retirement contribution. Type: single. Options: Yes, and I know the rate (with an optional rate field) · Yes, but I don't know the rate · No employer contribution · Not applicable in my country · Prefer not to say. Note: Not applicable in my country is present because mandatory and voluntary retirement provision differ fundamentally between jurisdictions, and an instrument that assumes one arrangement produces missing data that looks like an absence of benefit.

Q34 — Non-cash benefits. Type: multi, no amounts. Options: Private medical cover · Life or income protection insurance · Company car or allowance · Additional paid leave above the statutory or contractual minimum · Paid professional membership or certification fees · Funded training or study · Share or equity scheme · Relocation support · Childcare or family support · None of these · Prefer not to say. Note: deliberately unvalued. Valuing benefits requires assumptions about tax and local market cost that would be invented, and an invented valuation folded into a total-reward figure is exactly the practice this series exists to avoid. Benefits are reported as prevalence within a cell, never as money.

For day-rate and self-employed respondents (routed from Q18)

Q35 — Day rate. Type: numeric with a basis selector. Optional. "What is your current charge-out rate to your client or agency?" Basis selector: per day · per hour. Plus: Is that the rate you receive, or the rate the agency charges the client? — What I receive · What the client is charged · Not sure. Note: the receive-versus-charged distinction is asked because both numbers circulate as "the rate" and they are not the same quantity. Without it, contractor rate data is the sum of two different measurements.

Q36 — Days worked. Type: single. "Roughly how many days did you work in the period?" Options: banded, plus Prefer not to say. Note: a rate is not an income. Utilisation, unpaid leave, unpaid sickness and gaps between assignments are the difference, and without days worked no honest comparison with an employee's salary is possible. The report presents rates and salaries as separate series and never converts between them — see SAL-06 §6.

Q37 — Costs borne by the respondent. Type: multi. Options: Own insurance · Own retirement provision · Own training · Own equipment or software · Accountancy or umbrella fees · Unpaid leave · None of these · Prefer not to say. Note: the costs an employee does not carry. Recorded so that any commentary comparing engagement types has to acknowledge them, rather than comparing a gross rate with a gross salary and calling it a finding.

Q38 — Rate movement. Type: single. "Compared with your previous engagement, is your current rate higher, the same, or lower?" Options: Higher · About the same · Lower · This is my first engagement · Prefer not to say. Note: direction only, with no magnitude. A directional item is robust to recall error; a remembered percentage is not, and would be a change statistic the sample cannot support.

Q39 — Pay change in the period (all respondents). Type: single. "Did your pay change during the period, and if so why?" Options: No change · Annual review or inflation-related increase · Promotion · Change of employer · Change of contract or engagement type · Reduction · Prefer not to say. Note: reasons, not amounts. It supports honest commentary on how pay moves without producing a year-on-year figure the cross-sectional design cannot support.

— 9. Block H — skills held and skills required

Two matrices over the same skill list, taken from the taxonomy in SAL-04. The list is presented facet by facet — technical, tool category, domain, data and AI, behavioural — with roughly ten items per screen.

Q40 — Skills held. Type: matrix. "For each of these, how would you describe your own capability?" Scale: [I don't use this](#) · [I can do it with support](#) · [I can do it independently](#) · [I set how it is done and others come to me for it](#). Note: behavioural anchors rather than [Beginner](#) / [Intermediate](#) / [Expert](#). Adjectival scales measure self-confidence, which varies systematically by group; "others come to me for it" is a claim about observable behaviour, which is harder to inflate without noticing.

Q41 — Skills required of you. Type: matrix over the same list. "In the last twelve months, which of these has your employer, client or a recruiter actually asked you for — in a job specification, an objective, an appraisal or an interview?" Scale: [Not asked](#) · [Mentioned](#) · [Explicitly required](#). Note: the wording is tightly bounded on purpose. It asks about a documented request in a stated window, not about the respondent's impression of "what the market wants". This is the difference between a measurable construct and a vibe, and SAL-04 §6 sets out exactly what the resulting variable may and may not be called. It is never reported as "market demand".

Q42 — Tools used. Type: multi, by category, with an optional free-text field per category. Categories: [Planning and scheduling software](#) · [Cost management or control system](#) · [Enterprise resource planning \(ERP\) system](#) · [Risk analysis or simulation tool](#) · [Business intelligence \(BI\) or dashboarding tool](#) · [Spreadsheet as the primary control tool](#) · [Document control system](#) · [Programming or scripting language](#) · [AI assistant or large language model tool](#). Note: categories are the published unit; product names are collected as free text and used only for coding. Publishing a ranked list of named products would function as a vendor endorsement, would date within a year, and would draw attention away from the finding that matters — which is which categories of capability a role is expected to have.

— 10. Block I — AI in the work

Q43 — Use. Type: multi. "In your controls work, have you used AI tools for any of these in the last twelve months?" Options: [drawn from the data-and-AI facet of SAL-04: Drafting or summarising documents](#) · [Analysing or cleaning data](#) · [Forecasting or trend analysis](#) · [Schedule analysis or scenario testing](#) · [Risk identification](#) · [Writing code, formulas or queries](#) · [Preparing reporting narrative](#) · [None of these](#).

Q44 — Sanction. Type: single. "Is that use permitted by your employer or client?" Options: [Yes, with a policy that covers it](#) · [Yes, informally](#) · [No policy exists](#) · [It is prohibited](#) · [Don't know](#). Note: the governance question that makes the usage question meaningful. Usage without permission status is a number without a control environment attached — and the presence or absence of a policy is a finding about employers, which is legitimate, rather than about individuals, which would not be.

Q45 — Validation practice. Type: single. "When you use an AI tool on work that goes to a client or into a report, what happens to the output?" Options: [I check every part of it before it is used](#) · [I check the parts I judge material](#) · [A colleague or reviewer checks it](#) · [It goes through the normal review the work would have anyway](#) · [It is generally used as produced](#) · [Not applicable](#).

Note: this is the Institute's position — AI proposes; the professional disposes — turned into a measured behaviour rather than an assertion. It is asked neutrally, with the least defensible option phrased without judgement, or nobody selects it.

Q46 — Training. Type: single. Options: [Employer-provided training on AI tools](#) · [Self-taught](#) · [Formal course or certification](#) · [No training](#) · [Prefer not to say](#).

— 11. Block J — satisfaction, mobility and transparency

Q47 — Satisfaction with reward. Type: scale, five points from [Very dissatisfied](#) to [Very satisfied](#), plus [Prefer not to say](#). "How satisfied are you with your total reward for the work you do?"

Q48 — Satisfaction with the role. Type: scale, same five points. Note: asked separately from Q47 because they move independently, and a single "job satisfaction" item would conflate them.

Q49 — Mobility. Type: single. "How likely are you to change employer or engagement in the next twelve months?" Options: five points from [Very unlikely](#) to [Very likely](#), plus [Already in the process](#) · [Prefer not to say](#).

Q50 — Reasons. Type: multi. Routing: shown if Q49 is [Likely](#), [Very likely](#) or [Already in the process](#). Options: [Pay](#) · [Progression](#) · [Work content](#) · [Management](#) · [Job security or project ending](#) · [Location or travel](#) · [Flexibility](#) · [Culture](#) · [Relocation or personal reasons](#) · [Other](#). Note: multi-select without a forced ranking. Forcing a single primary reason produces "pay" from people whose real reason is their manager.

Q51 — Pay transparency at your employer. Type: single. Options: [Pay ranges are published internally](#) · [Ranges exist but are not shared](#) · [Pay is individually negotiated with no published structure](#) · [Don't know](#) · [Prefer not to say](#). Note: a structural fact about the employer, asked without implying that any arrangement is required. Pay-transparency law differs sharply between jurisdictions and the instrument takes no position on any of them.

— 12. Block K — free text and close

Q52 — Open question. Type: text, optional. "Is there anything about how project controls work is paid or valued that this survey has not asked about?" Note: one open question, at the end, deliberately broad. It is the instrument's own error-detection mechanism: recurring themes here become questions in the next cycle. Responses are coded under [SAL-04](#) §5 and screened for identifying detail before coding, and identifying detail is removed rather than paraphrased.

Q53 — Report notification. Type: single plus optional email field. "Would you like us to email you when the report is published?" Note: the email address is stored separately from the response and is not joined back to it. If it were joined, the promise of non-identification in Block A would be false.

Q54 — Follow-up. Type: single. [\[CONFIRM: whether respondents may opt in to a follow-up panel or to longitudinal linkage across cycles, and the separate consent wording and identifier scheme that would require — pending legal review\]](#)

Closing screen. Thanks, the reference for withdrawal, a link to the published methodology ([SAL-01](#)), and a link to the role taxonomy ([SAL-03](#)) for anyone who wants to see how their answers will be classified. No offer, no upsell, no certification marketing on the closing screen of a research instrument.

— 13. Routing map

From	Condition	To
Q01	No	Exit, nothing retained
Q02	None of these, or supplier-to-the-field option	Exit with thanks
Q05	No	Exit with thanks
Q07	Any role	Q08
Q18	Employee, fixed-term, agency or secondee	Q29–Q34, then Q39
Q18	Day rate (own company or umbrella), self-employed	Q35–Q38, then Q39
Q19	Part time	Q20
Q49	Likely, Very likely, Already in the process	Q50

Everything else runs in order. There are no display conditions based on a previous pay answer, because adaptive pay routing lets a respondent infer what the instrument expects.

— 14. Fielding notes

Length. Target fifteen minutes. The remuneration and skills blocks are the ones that matter, so they are protected; anything added in a future cycle displaces something rather than extending the survey.

Order. Screening, then role, then context, then pay, then skills, then attitudes. Pay sits in the middle: early enough that the fatigued respondents have not yet dropped out, late enough that the respondent has already invested effort and has been reminded, by the context questions, of the specifics of their own situation.

Mobile and save-and-resume. A meaningful share of respondents will start on a phone. Matrices are paged rather than scrolled sideways, and a partially completed response can be resumed from the same device.

Translation. [CONFIRM: which languages the instrument is translated into for the first cycle, and who performs the reconciliation review of the back-translation] — the platform's examination interface supports several languages, but a survey translation is a separate exercise requiring back-translation and reconciliation, because a mistranslated pay question produces confidently wrong data.

Accessibility. Every question is answerable with a keyboard and readable by a screen reader; no meaning is carried by colour; matrices carry row and column headers; no question relies on a drag-and-drop interaction.

Piloting. The instrument is piloted with a small group across at least three sectors and three countries before fielding, timed, and debriefed on comprehension — particularly the level descriptors at Q09 and the receive-versus-charged distinction at Q35. Pilot responses are excluded from the analysis dataset.

— 15. How this goes wrong

One pay question. The single most common failure: "What is your salary?" and a box. The answers are a mixture of base, total cash, and something the respondent computed in their head from a day rate. No amount of analysis recovers the components afterwards.

Showing a band to "help" the respondent. A well-meaning designer adds an example or a slider with a default position. Every answer thereafter is measured from that anchor.

Mandatory pay questions. Forcing an answer converts non-response into fabrication, and fabrication is undetectable where refusal would have been visible.

Titles as the classification variable. Coding by Q06 instead of Q07 and Q09 would be quicker and would produce cells that are not comparable across employers.

Silent improvement between cycles. A question is reworded for clarity and the series is compared anyway. Every change goes in the change log, and a changed question breaks its own series.

Marketing on the closing screen. A research instrument that ends in a sales pitch teaches respondents what the research was for, and they answer accordingly next year.

— 16. Checklist — before this instrument is fielded

- [] Every bracketed [CONFIRM](#) marker in Block A resolved by legal review in every jurisdiction of fielding
 - [] No figure, band, default or example value appears anywhere before a respondent's own answer
 - [] Every remuneration question offers Prefer not to say and none is mandatory
 - [] Employee and day-rate routing verified end to end, in both directions
 - [] Currency and gross/net basis asked before any amount field
 - [] Period selectors present on every amount field
 - [] Employer identifier hashed on receipt, plain text discarded, purpose stated at the point of asking
 - [] Email addresses stored separately from responses, with no join key
 - [] Role and level definitions linked and matching [SAL-03](#) exactly
 - [] Skill lists match the current version of the [SAL-04](#) codebook
 - [] Translations back-translated and reconciled
 - [] Pilot completed, timed and debriefed; pilot data excluded
 - [] Question numbers unchanged from the previous cycle wherever the wording is unchanged
 - [] Change log updated for every wording change, however small
-

— Related

- [SAL-01 – Salary and skills report – framework and methodology](#) — the sampling, suppression and disclosure rules this instrument serves
 - [SAL-03 – Role taxonomy and levelling](#) — the definitions behind Q07, Q08 and Q09
-

- [SAL-04 – The skills demand taxonomy](#) — the skill list and the coding rules for Q40, Q41, Q42 and Q52
- [SAL-05 – Report template and data tables](#) — where each question's output lands, and the instrument change log

— Sources and standards

No external source is cited. The design decisions above rest on the Institute's own editorial standard ([00-framework/EDITORIAL-STANDARD.md](#) §4) and on the canonical facts register for credential names, membership grades and eligibility ([00-framework/CANONICAL-FACTS.md](#) §1, §4.4 and §6). Where the instrument relies on established survey-methodology practice — behavioural anchors, back-translation with reconciliation, separating target from actual variable pay — the practice is described in our own words; the methodology annex of the published report will cite the specific texts the research lead relies on. The consent and privacy wording in §2 is a drafting starting point only and carries no legal review.

— Status and version

Founding-stage document · Version 1.0 · draft · Reviewed under PCI governance. PCI makes no claims of accreditation or recognition beyond what is true today.

SAL-03 · SALARY AND SKILLS REPORT

Role taxonomy and levelling

Ten canonical roles and a rubric that makes "senior" mean the same thing twice

VERSION 1.0 · DRAFT

2026-08-04

PROJECT CONTROLS INSTITUTE GLOBAL, INC.

AI proposes. The professional disposes.

— Summary

Ten canonical project controls roles, each defined by what it is accountable for rather than what it is called, and a four-level rubric that levels a person on autonomy, scope, judgement and accountability instead of tenure or title. Together they are the classification the Institute's salary and skills survey uses, the aggregation hierarchy that governs how thin data may be combined, and a usable job architecture for any organisation that has never written one down.

— About this document

Document	SAL-03
Series	Salary and Skills Report
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Unresolved placeholders	3

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Contents

1. Why titles cannot be the unit of comparison.....	4
2. How to use this taxonomy	4
3. The ten canonical roles	5
3.1 Planner / scheduler	5
3.2 Cost engineer	5
3.3 Cost controller	5
3.4 Estimator	6
3.5 Risk analyst.....	6
3.6 Change / commercial controller	6
3.7 Reporting and data analyst.....	6
3.8 Project controls lead.....	7
3.9 Project controls manager	7
3.10 Head of project controls.....	7
4. The levelling rubric	7
5. Applying the rubric	8
6. Aggregation hierarchy	9
7. Mapping to the competency framework.....	9
8. Coding rules for free-text titles.....	10
9. How this goes wrong	11
10. Checklist — matching a job to this taxonomy.....	11
Related	11
Sources and standards.....	12
Status and version	12

Role taxonomy and levelling

In one paragraph. This document defines ten canonical project controls roles, each by what it is accountable for rather than what it is called, and a four-level rubric that levels a person on autonomy, scope, judgement and accountability instead of tenure or title. Together they are the classification the Institute's salary and skills survey uses, the aggregation hierarchy that governs how thin data may be combined, and a usable job architecture for any organisation that has never written one down.

Who this is for. Heads of project controls and reward specialists doing job matching or building a career structure; practitioners working out which role and level genuinely describes them; and the analysts coding survey responses.

— 1. Why titles cannot be the unit of comparison

On a single site it is normal to find a "senior planner" who owns the integrated programme for a multi-contractor scope, and a "planning manager" who maintains one contractor's schedule and reports it upward. Both titles are honest inside their own organisations. Compared with each other, they are noise.

Titles inflate over time, deflate under headcount pressure, absorb local convention, and are frequently used as a substitute for pay. They are also the only classification most market data uses — the single largest reason published pay figures for this profession are unreliable. The cell labelled "planner" contains four different jobs.

The alternative is not complicated. Classify on two axes that describe the work rather than the label: **what the person is accountable for** (the role) and **how much judgement and scope they carry** (the level). A cost engineer at practitioner level in a contractor organisation is a recognisable, comparable thing in Perth, Riyadh and Rotterdam. "Senior cost engineer" is not.

— 2. How to use this taxonomy

In the survey. Question Q07 in [SAL-02](#) asks for the role by what the respondent spends most of their time doing; Q09 asks for the level using the behavioural descriptors in §4 below; Q06 captures the employer's title as free text and is never used as the classification variable. Coding rules are in §8.

In an organisation. The ten roles and four levels are a job architecture you may adopt directly. They are deliberately fewer than most internal structures, because a taxonomy with forty roles cannot be applied consistently by the twelve people who have to apply it.

What this is not. Not a pay structure, and it carries no pay implication of any kind. Not a statement that every organisation needs all ten roles — most need three or four. And not a competency framework: competence is defined in the Institute's competency series, which this document maps to rather than duplicates (see §7).

[CONFIRM: whether this taxonomy is ratified by the Standards Committee as the Institute's published job architecture, or published as a research instrument only]

— 3. The ten canonical roles

Each definition states the role's purpose, what it is accountable for, the artefacts it owns, the decision it is trusted with, and the boundary that most often gets blurred. The Body of Knowledge domains are given by number, per [docs/bok/](#).

3.1 Planner / scheduler

Purpose. To construct and maintain the model of how the work will be sequenced in time, and to tell the truth about where it currently is against that model.

Accountable for. Schedule structure and logic; the baseline and its integrity; progress capture and status; critical path and float analysis; time impact of change. **Owns.** The programme or schedule file, the schedule basis and assumptions document, the progress report, the schedule narrative. **Trusted to decide.** How the work is logically represented, and what the schedule says about completion — including when that is unwelcome. **Boundary.** A planner is not a progress clerk. Where the role is only updating percentages supplied by others, that is a foundation-level activity within the role, not the role itself. **BoK domains.** 10 (scheduling), 8 (lifecycle), 6 (earned value forecasting), 12 (risk).

3.2 Cost engineer

Purpose. To connect scope, quantity and money — building the cost model and keeping it consistent with what is actually being built.

Accountable for. The cost breakdown structure and its alignment to the work breakdown structure; budgets and commitments at control-account level; unit rates and quantities; cost impact of change; the data behind the forecast. **Owns.** The cost model, the control-account budget, the variance analysis, the cost basis of estimate at completion (EAC). **Trusted to decide.** How cost is structured and how a variance is explained. **Boundary.** The cost engineer builds and analyses; the cost controller runs the periodic control cycle. In smaller teams one person does both, and in the survey they pick the larger half of their time. **BoK domains.** 5 (cost management), 3 (budgeting and forecasting), 6 (EVM/EAC), 1 (accounting foundations).

3.3 Cost controller

Purpose. To operate the monthly control cycle so that reported cost is complete, cut off correctly and reconciled to the accounts.

Accountable for. Commitment and expenditure capture; accruals and cut-off; reconciliation between the project ledger and the finance system; invoice and payment status; the integrity of the reported actuals. **Owns.** The cost report, the accrual schedule, the reconciliation, the cost ledger interface. **Trusted to decide.** What is accrued, what is deferred, and when the books close. **Boundary.** Not project accounting, and not management accounting. The cost controller is accountable for the project's numbers being right and reconcilable, not for the entity's financial statements. **BoK domains.** 5, 4 (performance management and management reporting), 11 (business process cycles), 2 (financial reporting).

3.4 Estimator

Purpose. To produce a defensible view of what work will cost before it is done, with the uncertainty stated.

Accountable for. Estimate structure, methodology and class; quantity take-off and pricing basis; benchmark and norm selection; allowances and the estimate's uncertainty range; the basis of estimate. **Owns.** The estimate, the basis of estimate, the estimate reconciliation between revisions. **Trusted to decide.** Method and class of estimate, and what is included in an allowance rather than a contingency. **Boundary.** The estimator sets the number the project starts with; the cost engineer controls it thereafter. Where they are the same person the roles must still be distinguished, because estimating your own control baseline is a governance weakness worth knowing about. **BoK domains.** 3, 5, 7 (contracts and commercial).

3.5 Risk analyst

Purpose. To make uncertainty explicit and quantified, so that decisions account for it rather than discovering it.

Accountable for. Risk identification and register quality; qualitative assessment discipline; quantitative cost and schedule risk analysis; contingency derivation and drawdown analysis; the link between risk and the forecast. **Owns.** The risk register, the quantitative schedule risk analysis (QSRA) model and its inputs, the contingency basis. **Trusted to decide.** How uncertainty is modelled, and what the analysis says about confidence in a target date or cost. **Boundary.** Not the risk owner. The analyst runs the process and the arithmetic; the accountable manager owns the risk and the response. **BoK domains.** 12 (risk), 10, 6.

3.6 Change / commercial controller

Purpose. To control the boundary between what was agreed and what is now being done, in both directions.

Accountable for. Change identification, valuation and authorisation; variation and instruction records; entitlement and notice discipline; claim and extension-of-time (EOT) substantiation; the commercial audit trail. **Owns.** The change register, the variation file, the claim narrative and its supporting records. **Trusted to decide.** Whether something is a change, and what evidence is required before it is valued. **Boundary.** Sits between project controls and the commercial or quantity surveying function, and in some organisations reports into the latter. The role is included here because the work is controls work wherever it reports. **BoK domains.** 7, 11, 5.

3.7 Reporting and data analyst

Purpose. To turn controls data into something a decision-maker can act on, without distorting it in transit.

Accountable for. Data model and data quality across controls systems; the reporting pipeline; dashboards and their definitions; automation of recurring reporting; increasingly, the responsible application of analytical and AI tooling to controls data. **Owns.** The data model, the dashboard definitions, the reporting calendar, the automation scripts. **Trusted to decide.** How a metric is defined and computed, and what a visualisation is allowed to imply. **Boundary.** Not a business-intelligence developer who happens to sit near a project: the role requires knowing what an earned-

value number means before displaying it. Distinguishing the two is one of the things this taxonomy exists to make possible. **BoK domains.** 4, 13 (AI for project controls), 6.

3.8 Project controls lead

Purpose. To integrate cost, schedule, risk and change on a project into one coherent account of status and forecast.

Accountable for. Integration across the controls disciplines; the integrity of the reported position; the controls calendar and cycle; the forecast the project reports; the quality of what the team produces. **Owns.** The project controls execution plan, the integrated report, the forecast position. **Trusted to decide.** What the project reports, and when a number is not yet fit to report. **Boundary.** A lead is defined by integration, not by headcount. A lead with no direct reports is normal; a "senior planner" who integrates cost, schedule and risk into a single reported position is functioning as a lead and is coded as one. **BoK domains.** 4, 5, 6, 10.

3.9 Project controls manager

Purpose. To run the controls function for a project, programme or business unit — its people, its methods and its standards.

Accountable for. The controls team and its capability; method, process and tooling; assurance over project reporting; interface with finance, commercial and delivery leadership; recruitment and development. **Owns.** The functional standard and procedures, the assurance regime, the resourcing plan. **Trusted to decide.** How controls is done here, and whether a project's reported position is credible enough to leave the function. **Boundary.** Distinguished from the lead by accountability for how the work is done across more than one delivery vehicle, rather than for one vehicle's numbers. **BoK domains.** 4, 8, 12, 5.

3.10 Head of project controls

Purpose. To own the controls capability of the organisation: its standard, its systems, its people pipeline and its voice at executive level.

Accountable for. The functional strategy and standard; systems and data architecture for controls; capability development and succession; governance and assurance across the portfolio; representing the integrity of reported performance to the board or client at the point where it is uncomfortable. **Owns.** The functional standard, the systems roadmap, the capability plan, the assurance framework. **Trusted to decide.** What the organisation's controls standard is, and what it will not report. **Boundary.** Titles vary widely at this level — director, head of function, discipline lead, chief. Classify on organisational scope, not on the word. **BoK domains.** 8, 4, 13.

A note on roles not listed. Document control, project accounting, quantity surveying, contract administration and project management proper are adjacent professions with their own structures. They are out of scope here rather than junior versions of anything above; the survey routes respondents in those roles out at screening.

— 4. The levelling rubric

Four levels, matching the Institute's competency levels so the survey and the competency framework can be read together: **foundation · practitioner · professional · leader (CMP-02).**

Two vocabulary warnings, both of which cause real confusion. First, professional here is a level on a competency scale — it is not the same idea as the level at which the Institute's credentials sit, which is Leader. Second, senior is not a level in this rubric and never will be, because it is the word employers use to mean whatever they need it to mean.

Levelling runs on six dimensions.

Dimension	Foundation	Practitioner	Professional	Leader
Autonomy	Works to instruction on defined tasks; output is checked	Works to an objective; chooses method within an established framework	Sets the approach for a scope and is relied on without checking	Sets the framework others work within
Scope owned	Part of a discipline on part of a project	A discipline on a project, or part of one on a large project	An integrated scope, a large or complex project, or a discipline across several	A function, a portfolio, or an organisational capability
Judgement under ambiguity	Escalates when data is missing or contradictory	Resolves routine ambiguity; escalates the novel	Makes and defends a call where the data does not settle it	Decides where reasonable experts disagree, and carries the consequence
Accountability for the number	Accurate execution of a defined calculation	The number for their scope, and its explanation	The reported position, including what it implies	The organisation's reported position and its integrity
Influence	Within the immediate team	Across the project team; explains to non-specialists	Persuades delivery and commercial leadership, including against preference	Board, client and external; sets expectations others must meet
Development of others and of method	Learning the method	Supports others; applies method as given	Improves method; coaches; reviews others' work	Owens the method; builds the capability and the pipeline

The signature test. Beyond the table, each level has work that only it does. Foundation produces accurate data. Practitioner produces a defensible answer. Professional produces a defensible answer that survives contact with someone who does not want to hear it. Leader decides what the organisation will stand behind, and is the person who says the number is not ready.

— 5. Applying the rubric

Nobody sits cleanly at one level on all six dimensions. The decision rule:

1. Score each of the six dimensions independently.
2. The assigned level is the one with the most dimensions. Ties are broken by **accountability for the number**, then by **autonomy** — the two that most reliably distinguish real from nominal seniority.
3. **The scope ceiling.** A person cannot be levelled above the scope they actually own. Someone with leader-level influence and practitioner-level scope is levelled on the scope. This rule prevents the most common inflation, which is levelling on visibility.
4. **Tenure is not a dimension.** Long service at one level is long service at one level.

5. **Headcount is not a dimension.** It appears nowhere in the table, deliberately: technical leadership without direct reports is real leadership in this discipline.

Where a survey respondent's self-assessment at Q09 conflicts with their answers on scope (Q12), reporting line (Q10) and role, the conflict is recorded but the self-assessment stands. Overriding it would replace a stated measurement with an analyst's inference, and inference cannot be disclosed to a reader in the way a rule can.

— 6. Aggregation hierarchy

[SAL-01](#) §6 rule 5 permits combining thin cells only along a hierarchy declared in advance. This is that hierarchy, and it may not be varied for a particular table.

Roles combine upward into four groups, and no further:

Group	Roles
Cost and commercial	Cost engineer · Cost controller · Estimator · Change / commercial controller
Planning and risk	Planner / scheduler · Risk analyst
Data and reporting	Reporting and data analyst
Controls leadership	Project controls lead · Project controls manager · Head of project controls

Levels combine only as adjacent pairs: foundation with practitioner, professional with leader. A combination spanning all four is never published, because a figure covering every level of a profession describes nobody in it.

Geography combines country into sub-region into region, along a stated list published with the report. Countries are never combined ad hoc to reach a threshold.

Every combined cell is labelled as combined, in the cell and not only in a footnote.

— 7. Mapping to the competency framework

The Institute's competency series ([CMP-01](#) to [CMP-10](#)) defines what competence looks like; this taxonomy defines what jobs exist and how they are levelled. The two meet at the level labels, which are shared, and at the competency sets.

For the project controls credential PCL-AI, the platform's seeded set of fourteen competencies maps to the roles as follows. Each role's primary competencies are those the role is accountable for; every role touches more.

Role	Primary PCL-AI competencies
Planner / scheduler	Planning and scheduling · Performance measurement · Project risk
Cost engineer	Cost management · Forecasting and EAC · Earned value management
Cost controller	Cost management · Performance measurement · Project controls governance
Estimator	Cost management · Forecasting and EAC
Risk analyst	Project risk · Predictive analytics · Forecasting and EAC
Change / commercial controller	Commercial and contract controls · Cost management
Reporting and data analyst	Digital reporting · Automation · AI-enabled project controls · Predictive analytics
Project controls lead	Performance measurement · Earned value management · Forecasting and EAC · Project controls governance
Project controls manager	Project controls governance · Human validation · Responsible AI
Head of project controls	Project controls governance · Responsible AI · Human validation

Two competencies — **responsible AI** and **human validation** — appear as primary only at manager and head level, and that placement is a position, not an oversight. Every role uses AI-assisted tooling; accountability for whether its output is fit to rely on escalates with the level that carries accountability for the reported number. This is the Institute's standing position — AI proposes; the professional disposes — expressed as a levelling consequence.

[CONFIRM: whether the role-to-competency mapping above is reviewed and endorsed by the Standards Committee before publication, or presented as an editorial mapping]

[CONFIRM: reconciliation of these role definitions with the task statements produced by the forthcoming PCL-AI job-task analysis, once that study has been run]

— 8. Coding rules for free-text titles

For analysts coding Q06 where Q07 was answered **Other**, or where a response is inconsistent.

1. Code from the accountability described, never from the title string alone.
2. Where a title contains two roles ("planning and cost engineer"), code the primary role from Q07 and record the second at Q08. Do not create hybrid categories.
3. Ignore all seniority words when assigning the role — senior, principal, lead, chief, junior, graduate, assistant, associate. They inform nothing about the role and are handled by the level, which is measured separately.
4. Treat "lead" in a title as evidence of the lead role only where the described accountability is integration across disciplines. Otherwise it is a level signal, not a role signal, and even then it is not decisive.
5. Where an employer's title has no relationship to the described work, code the work and flag the record. Flagged records are counted and the count is published.
6. Where a role genuinely falls outside the ten, code it **OTHER** with the verbatim description retained. **OTHER** is reported as a count and never distributed across the ten to tidy the table.

7. Double-code a sample of records independently and report the agreement, under the same rules the skills codebook uses ([SAL-04 §5](#)).

— 9. How this goes wrong

Levelling on title after all. The rubric is adopted, then someone maps titles to levels once and applies the mapping thereafter. Within two cycles the data is title data with a rubric-shaped label on it.

Levelling on tenure. Fifteen years in the same role becomes "professional" because it feels disrespectful not to. The scope ceiling in §5 exists for this moment.

Headcount as the leadership test. A technically formidable practitioner who owns the method for a portfolio is levelled below a manager of three, because one has reports and the other does not. In this discipline that is usually the wrong way round.

The everything role. In a small organisation one person is planner, cost engineer, risk analyst and lead. Coding them into all four inflates every cell; coding them into the largest half of their time, with the second recorded, is the only defensible option and must be applied consistently.

Roles invented to fit an internal structure. An organisation adopts the taxonomy and adds four local roles. Legitimate internally, fatal to comparison — local roles must resolve back to one of the ten before any figure is compared with anyone else's.

Assuming the taxonomy is a pay ladder. The ten roles are not ordered by value and the four levels carry no pay implication. The honest use is job matching, after which pay is a separate question with its own evidence.

— 10. Checklist — matching a job to this taxonomy

- [] Read the job's accountabilities, not its title
 - [] Identify what artefact the job owns and what decision it is trusted with
 - [] Choose the role by where most of the time goes; record a second role if the split is genuine
 - [] Score all six levelling dimensions independently before deciding the level
 - [] Apply the scope ceiling: no level above the scope actually owned
 - [] Check the tie-breakers — accountability for the number, then autonomy
 - [] Confirm tenure and headcount played no part in the decision
 - [] Record any conflict between the self-assessed level and the scope answers
 - [] Where the role does not fit, code it as other and keep the description — do not force it
 - [] Re-read the resulting classification and ask whether two people classified identically would recognise each other's jobs
-

— Related

- [SAL-02 – The survey instrument](#) — the questions this taxonomy classifies, and the definitions linked from them

- [SAL-04 – The skills demand taxonomy](#) — the skills vocabulary applied across these roles
- [SAL-05 – Report template and data tables](#) — where role and level become reporting dimensions
- [CMP-01 – The PCI competency framework – overview](#) — what competence means, as distinct from what a job is
- [CMP-02 – Competency levels and how they are evidenced](#) — the shared level labels and the evidence each requires
- [CAR-01 – The project controls career roadmap](#) — how a career moves through these roles and levels

— Sources and standards

No external source is cited. The competency names in §7 are the Institute's own seeded competency set for PCL-AI as recorded in [00-framework/CANONICAL-FACTS.md](#) §7; the level labels are those used by the competency series and the framework's front-matter schema. Body of Knowledge domain numbers refer to the thirteen domains in [docs/bok/](#). The role definitions are the Institute's editorial synthesis of how the work is organised across sectors; they are not drawn from, and do not reproduce, any other body's job architecture.

— Status and version

Founding-stage document · Version 1.0 · draft · Reviewed under PCI governance. PCI makes no claims of accreditation or recognition beyond what is true today.

SAL-04 · SALARY AND SKILLS REPORT

The skills demand taxonomy

A controlled vocabulary for skills, and an honest definition of what "demand" can mean

VERSION 1.0 · DRAFT

2026-08-04

PROJECT CONTROLS INSTITUTE GLOBAL, INC.

AI proposes. The professional disposes.

— Summary

The structured vocabulary the Institute's salary and skills report uses to classify skills across five facets — technical method, tool category, domain, data and AI, and behavioural — with a permanent code for each, the rules for coding free text into it, and a precise definition of what the report may call "demand". The short version of that definition: what respondents were asked for is a reported requirement, not market demand, and the report says so in those words.

— About this document

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Contents

1. What goes wrong when skills are counted without a vocabulary	4
2. Five facets	4
3. The vocabulary	5
3.1 Facet T — technical method	6
3.2 Facet L — tool category	8
3.3 Facet D — domain	9
3.4 Facet A — data and AI	10
3.5 Facet B — behavioural	10
4. Skill entries — what a code carries	11
5. Coding free text into the vocabulary	11
6. What "demand" may mean here	11
7. Reporting rules for skills findings	12
8. How this goes wrong	13
9. Checklist — before a skills finding is published	13
Related	14
Sources and standards	14
Status and version	14

The skills demand taxonomy

In one paragraph. This document defines the structured vocabulary the Institute's salary and skills report uses to classify skills across five facets — technical method, tool category, domain, data and AI, and behavioural — with a permanent code for each, the rules for coding free text into it, and a precise definition of what the report may call "demand". The short version of that definition: what respondents were asked for is a reported requirement, not market demand, and the report says so in those words.

Who this is for. Analysts coding survey responses; heads of function and capability leads who need a skills vocabulary that does not change every time a tool is renamed; and anyone assessing whether a published skills statistic means what its headline says.

— 1. What goes wrong when skills are counted without a vocabulary

Ask a hundred practitioners what skills their job requires and you get a hundred phrasings of perhaps thirty things. "Forecasting", "EAC", "estimate at completion", "predicting the outturn" and "cost projection" are one skill written five ways. "Data skills" is between four and nine different skills depending on who wrote it. "Excel" is a tool, a proxy for modelling capability, and sometimes a complaint.

Left uncoded, that free text produces a ranked list whose ordering is an artefact of vocabulary rather than of anything in the world — the skill with the most common single phrasing wins. Coded carelessly, it produces something worse: a list that looks authoritative and is unreproducible, because the person who made the coding decisions did not write them down.

A controlled vocabulary fixes both, and costs something in return. It cannot represent a skill nobody anticipated, and it imposes boundaries that will occasionally be wrong. The compensating controls are in §5: unmatched text is coded as unmatched and reported rather than forced, and the codebook has a defined review point where new codes are added — deliberately not continuously, because a vocabulary that changes mid-cycle cannot be compared with itself.

— 2. Five facets

Skills are classified on five facets. A facet is not a level of importance; it is a kind of skill, and each kind behaves differently over time and needs different treatment in analysis.

Facet	Code	What it holds	Why it is separate
Technical method	T	The discipline itself — how the work is done, independent of any tool	The slowest-moving facet, and the one the Body of Knowledge maps to directly
Tool category	L	Categories of software and platform, never named products	Products churn; categories persist. Naming products would date within a year and function as endorsement
Domain	D	Sector, contracting model and standards context	Portable-looking skills are often domain-bound, and this facet is what reveals it
Data and AI	A	Data handling, analysis, automation and the responsible use of AI tooling	The fastest-moving facet; kept separate so its volatility does not contaminate the others
Behavioural	B	Professional behaviour and judgement	Measurable only through anchored self-report, and reported with heavier caveats than the rest

Code structure: **FACET-GROUP-SKILL**, for example **T-EVM-EAC**. Codes are permanent. A retired code is never reused for a different skill, for the same reason a document ID is never reused: it is a citation key, and anyone comparing two cycles must be able to trust that the same code means the same thing.

— 3. The vocabulary

Each entry gives the code, the skill, what it means in one line, and what evidence of it looks like — the evidence column is what makes the code applicable by two different analysts to the same free text.

3.1 Facet T — technical method

Code	Skill	What it means	What evidence looks like	BoK
T-PLN-DEV	Schedule development	Building a schedule that represents how the work will actually be done	A network with defensible logic and a written schedule basis	10
T-PLN-INT	Network and logic integrity	Keeping the schedule's logic sound as it changes	Diagnosed and corrected logic defects; documented open ends and constraints	10
T-PLN-PRG	Progress measurement	Establishing how progress is claimed and verified	Rules of credit applied consistently across a scope	6
T-PLN-CPA	Critical path and float analysis	Reading what the network says about completion and slack	Float analysis that changed a decision	10
T-PLN-TIA	Time impact analysis	Isolating the schedule effect of a discrete event	A modelled impact that survived challenge	10, 7
T-CST-CBS	Cost structure design	Designing a cost breakdown that aligns to scope and to the accounts	A cost breakdown structure mapped to both the work breakdown structure and the code of accounts	5
T-CST-BUD	Budgeting and control accounts	Distributing a budget into controllable units	Control accounts with named owners	3, 5
T-CST-ACT	Commitment and actual capture	Getting real cost into the report completely and on time	Committed, incurred and paid tracked distinctly	5, 11
T-CST-ACC	Accruals and cut-off	Reporting the period's cost in the period	An accrual schedule that reconciles to finance	2, 11
T-CST-VAR	Variance analysis	Explaining a difference in terms someone can act on	Variance narrative naming cause, not restating the number	4, 5
T-EST-QTO	Quantity take-off	Deriving quantities from a design of stated maturity	Take-off with a stated source and maturity	3
T-EST-MTH	Estimate method and class	Choosing a method appropriate to definition and stating its class	An estimate labelled by class with an accuracy range stated as a range concept	3
T-EST-BEN	Benchmarking and norms	Using comparable data critically, including rejecting it	A norm applied with a documented adjustment	3
T-EST-BOE	Basis of estimate	Writing down what the estimate assumes, includes and excludes	A basis document a stranger could audit	3
T-EVM-TEC	Earned value technique selection	Choosing a measurement method suited to the work type	Technique chosen per work package, not per project	6
T-EVM-IND	Performance indices	Computing and, more importantly, interpreting indices	An index read alongside its data quality, not in isolation	6
T-FCT-EAC	Estimate at completion	Selecting, computing and defending a forecast method	Multiple methods compared and one chosen with a reason	6, 3
T-FCT-CSH	Cash flow forecasting	Forecasting the timing of money, not only its total	A profile reconciled to schedule and to commercial terms	3, 7
	Risk identification			12

Code	Skill	What it means	What evidence looks like	BoK
T-RSK-IDN		Surfacing what could happen, in usable form	Risks written as cause-event-effect, not as concerns	
T-RSK-QNT	Quantitative risk analysis	Modelling uncertainty in cost or schedule	A simulation with defensible ranges and correlation treatment	12
T-RSK-CTG	Contingency derivation and drawdown	Deriving contingency from analysis and controlling its release	Contingency traced to risks and drawn down against them	12, 3
T-COM-CHG	Change identification and valuation	Recognising a change and pricing it	A change register where the entry date matches the event	7
T-COM-ENT	Entitlement and notice	Managing the records that make a position defensible	Notices issued in time, with contemporaneous records	7
T-COM-CLM	Claims and extension of time	Constructing a substantiated narrative from records	A claim narrative supported by its own evidence trail	7
T-GOV-BLC	Baseline control	Keeping the baseline meaningful under change	A change-controlled baseline with a traceable history	4, 8
T-GOV-PCE	Controls execution planning	Writing down how controls will be run before running it	A project controls execution plan in use, not filed	8
T-GOV-ASR	Assurance and health check	Testing whether reported performance is credible	A health check that produced corrective actions	4
T-RPT-MGT	Management reporting	Producing reporting that changes a decision	A report whose recommendations were acted on	4

3.2 Facet L — tool category

Code	Category	Scope of the code
L-SCH	Planning and scheduling software	Any critical-path scheduling platform
L-CST	Cost management or control system	Dedicated project cost control platforms
L-ERP	Enterprise resource planning system	Finance and procurement systems as they touch project cost
L-RSK	Risk analysis and simulation tools	Quantitative cost and schedule risk platforms
L-BI	Business intelligence and dashboarding	Reporting and visualisation platforms
L-SPR	Spreadsheet as a primary control tool	Including structured modelling, not incidental use
L-DOC	Document control and correspondence systems	Including the controls-relevant record trail
L-COD	Programming or scripting	Any language used to manipulate controls data
L-AIT	AI assistant or large language model tooling	General-purpose and embedded assistants
L-INT	System integration and interfacing	Moving data between the above without losing its meaning

Named products are never published. They are collected as free text at Q42 (SAL-02) and used only to assign the category. Publishing a ranked list of products would function as an endorsement the Institute has no basis to give, would age within a year, and would distract from the finding that

matters: which categories of capability a role is expected to hold. [CONFIRM: whether an annex lists the named products encountered, in alphabetical order with no counts and an explicit non-endorsement statement, or whether product names are discarded entirely after coding]

3.3 Facet D — domain

Code	Domain skill	What it means
D-SEC-HVY	Heavy industrial and energy delivery	Controls practice under the constraints of large capital plant and site delivery
D-SEC-INF	Infrastructure and transport	Long linear or networked assets, often publicly scrutinised
D-SEC-BLD	Buildings and property	Trade-package structures and shorter cycles
D-SEC-REG	Highly regulated environments	Nuclear, pharmaceutical, defence and similar: qualification and evidence regimes that change how controls is done
D-SEC-CHG	Technology and business-change portfolios	Iterative delivery where scope is discovered rather than specified
D-CON-LSM	Lump sum and fixed price	Controls under fixed-price commercial pressure
D-CON-REI	Reimbursable and target cost	Open-book regimes, pain-gain mechanisms, client audit
D-CON-ALL	Alliance and integrated delivery	Shared-risk arrangements and their reporting demands
D-CON-PPP	Concessions and public-private arrangements	Long-horizon financing structures as they constrain controls
D-STD-EVM	Earned value guidance and its conventions	Working to a recognised earned value management framework
D-STD-RSK	Risk management standards	Applying recognised risk principles, such as those in ISO 31000
D-STD-TCM	Total cost management practice	Working within the AACE International total cost management body of practice
D-STD-PMB	Project management frameworks	PMBOK and comparable frameworks as they meet controls
D-STD-AGL	Adaptive delivery frameworks	Scrum and comparable approaches, and their controls implications

3.4 Facet A — data and AI

Code	Skill	What it means	BoK
A-DQL	Data quality and structure	Knowing whether the data can bear the analysis about to be done to it	13, 4
A-MDL	Data modelling for controls	Structuring controls data so cost, schedule and change can be joined	13
A-ANL	Analysis and applied statistics	Trend, distribution and comparison, used correctly	13, 4
A-VIS	Visualisation and metric definition	Defining a metric precisely and displaying it without distorting it	4
A-AUT	Automation of recurring work	Removing manual steps from a reporting cycle reliably	13
A-PRD	Predictive and machine-assisted forecasting	Using algorithmic methods to support a forecast a human still owns	13, 6
A-PRM	Task framing for AI tools	Specifying a task to an AI tool precisely enough to get usable output	13
A-VAL	Validation of AI output	Checking what a tool produced before anyone relies on it	13
A-EXP	Explainability and bias awareness	Understanding what a model did and where it can be systematically wrong	13
A-GOV	AI governance and permissible use	Knowing what is allowed, recording what was used, and keeping the audit trail	13

A-VAL and A-GOV carry the Institute's position directly: AI proposes; the professional disposes. They are separate codes rather than an aspect of the others because they are separately absent — a respondent can be fluent with the tools and have no validation practice at all, and that combination is precisely what a skills report should be able to see.

3.5 Facet B — behavioural

Code	Skill	What it means
B-COM	Explaining a number to a non-specialist	Making a forecast or variance land with someone who does not do this job
B-POS	Holding a position under pressure	Maintaining a defensible number when it is unwelcome
B-STK	Stakeholder management	Working across client, contractor and function boundaries
B-COL	Cross-discipline collaboration	Working effectively with delivery, commercial and finance
B-JUD	Judgement under incomplete data	Deciding when the data will not settle it, and saying what is assumed
B-LRN	Method improvement	Improving how the work is done, not only doing it
B-DEV	Developing others	Building capability in a team
B-ETH	Professional conduct	Recognising and escalating a reporting integrity problem

Behavioural codes are reported with the heaviest caveats in the report, because they rest entirely on anchored self-report. [SAL-02 Q40](#) uses behavioural anchors precisely to make this facet less self-flattering, and the limitation is stated wherever a behavioural finding appears.

— 4. Skill entries — what a code carries

Every code in the master codebook carries seven fields, and a code without all seven is not fielded: the code itself; the facet; the display label used in the instrument; the one-line definition; the evidence descriptor; the mapped Body of Knowledge domain or domains; and the cycle in which the code was introduced. Retired codes additionally carry the cycle of retirement and the reason.

— 5. Coding free text into the vocabulary

Free text arrives from three places: the "other" fields at Q07 and Q25, the product names at Q42, and the open question at Q52.

The procedure.

1. **Screen for identifying detail first.** Employer names, project names, colleagues' names and anything else identifying is removed — removed, not paraphrased — before any coding begins.
2. **Code to the vocabulary, or to UNC.** A segment of text is assigned one or more codes. Where no code fits, it is coded [UNC](#) (unmatched) with the text retained. [UNC](#) is reported as a count. It is never distributed across neighbouring codes to make a table look complete.
3. **Code segments, not responses.** One open answer may carry three skills; forcing one code per respondent silently discards two-thirds of what was said.
4. **Double-code independently.** A defined share of the free text is coded by two analysts working separately, and their agreement is measured with a named statistic — Cohen's kappa for two coders on nominal codes, or Krippendorff's alpha where more than two coders or partial agreement are involved. The statistic and the minimum acceptable value are fixed before coding begins [\[CONFIRM: which agreement statistic is used and the minimum acceptable value below which coding is redone rather than reconciled\]](#).
5. **Resolve disagreements by rule, not by seniority.** A third analyst adjudicates; the adjudication is recorded; if the same boundary is adjudicated repeatedly, that is a codebook defect and goes to the review point rather than being absorbed by the analysts.
6. **Do not add codes mid-cycle.** New codes are added only at the codebook review, between cycles. A vocabulary that grows during coding cannot be compared with itself, and the first responses coded were coded under a different scheme from the last.
7. **Publish the codebook version** used for each cycle, with the change log [\[CONFIRM: codebook owner, version numbering scheme and the review point at which new codes may be introduced\]](#).

— 6. What "demand" may mean here

This is the section that decides whether the skills half of the report is research or decoration. The instrument measures three distinct constructs, and the report never merges them or lets one borrow the other's name.

Construct 1 — reported requirement. From Q41: a respondent states that a skill was explicitly required of them, in a documented form (job specification, objective, appraisal or interview), within the twelve months to the reference date. What it measures: what these respondents were asked for. What it does not measure: what employers who did not respond want, what unfilled vacancies specify, or what anyone will want next year.

Construct 2 — held capability. From Q40: a respondent's anchored self-assessment of what they can do. What it measures: claimed capability among respondents. What it does not measure: assessed competence — that requires assessment, which is what the Institute's certification does and this survey does not.

Construct 3 — capability gap. Computed within a respondent: a skill explicitly required at Q41 and held at the two lowest anchors at Q40. Computed per person and then counted, never inferred by comparing two aggregate distributions — comparing a required-skills distribution with a held-skills distribution across different people produces a "gap" that may not exist for any individual.

Economists mean something specific by demand: a schedule of quantity against price, evidenced by vacancies, time-to-fill and wage movement. The Institute's survey collects none of that. It therefore never uses the word without qualification.

Never written	Written instead
"The most in-demand skill in project controls"	"The skill most often reported as explicitly required by respondents in this cell"
"Demand for X grew"	"A larger share of respondents reported X as explicitly required than in the previous cycle" — and only where §7 permits a comparison at all
"There is a shortage of X"	"A capability gap for X was reported by respondents in this cell"
"Employers want X"	"Respondents reported that X was required of them"
"X is the future of the profession"	Nothing. This is not a measurement

Every one of the permitted forms is longer and duller than the phrase it replaces. That is the cost of saying only what was measured, and it is the whole reason to read the report rather than a headline about it.

— 7. Reporting rules for skills findings

1. **Cell thresholds apply identically.** The minimum response counts and suppression rules in [SAL-01 §6](#) govern skills findings exactly as they govern pay findings. A skills table is not exempt because it contains no money.
2. **Item-level denominators.** Skills matrices lose respondents partway through. Every skills figure carries the count of respondents who answered that item, not the survey total.
3. **Ranks are bands.** Where the difference between adjacent skills is within the reporting precision, they are shown as a tied band. A ranked list with no tie rule invites readers to treat noise as order.
4. **No top-ten lists without the whole list.** Publishing only the top of a ranking hides how flat the ranking is. The full ordering is published in an annex whenever any part of it is quoted.

5. **No cross-cycle skills comparison** unless the item wording, the anchors and the code were all unchanged, and both cycles meet the cell threshold. Adding a skill to the vocabulary resets that skill's series to its first cycle.
6. **Facet A findings carry a currency warning.** The data and AI facet moves fastest; a finding from it is labelled with its reference period wherever it appears, because a twelve-month-old statement about AI tool use is a historical statement.
7. **Behavioural findings carry the self-report caveat** in the same paragraph, not in a footnote.

— 8. How this goes wrong

The vocabulary becomes a wish list. Someone adds the skills the Institute would like the profession to value. The vocabulary must describe what exists, including the parts nobody is proud of — the spreadsheet category exists for exactly that reason.

Tool codes swallow method codes. A respondent who names a scheduling product is coded as having schedule development capability. They are different things, and the facet separation exists to keep them apart.

Coding drift. Over a long coding run, a boundary case is decided one way early and the other way late. Double-coding a sample at the start, middle and end of the run catches it; a single agreement check at the start does not.

UNC gets tidied away. Unmatched text is the taxonomy's error signal. Distributing it into the nearest codes destroys the only evidence that the vocabulary is incomplete.

The gap that exists only in aggregate. Two distributions are compared, a difference appears, and it is reported as a skills gap. Construct 3 is computed per respondent for this reason.

"Demand" leaks back in. The report is careful and the promotional post is not. The language table in §6 applies to the headline, the social copy and the conference slide, not only to the body text.

— 9. Checklist — before a skills finding is published

- [] Every code used is in the published codebook version for this cycle
- [] Identifying detail removed from free text before coding, not after
- [] Double-coded sample drawn from across the whole coding run, and agreement reported
- [] **UNC** count reported, and no **UNC** text redistributed
- [] No code added mid-cycle
- [] Item-level response count shown on every skills figure
- [] Ranked lists carry a tie rule; nothing quoted from a ranking without the full ordering available
- [] Construct named explicitly — reported requirement, held capability or capability gap
- [] The word "demand" checked against the language table in §6, in the report and in every derived post
- [] Facet A findings labelled with their reference period; facet B findings carry the self-report caveat
- [] No product name published in any ranked or counted form

— Related

- [SAL-02 – The survey instrument](#) — the skills matrices, tool question and open question this vocabulary codes
- [SAL-03 – Role taxonomy and levelling](#) — the roles these skills are reported against
- [SAL-05 – Report template and data tables](#) — the skills tables and their standing caveats
- [CMP-08 – Data, digital and AI competencies in depth](#) — what competence in the data and AI facet actually requires
- [AIG-12 – The AI-literate controls professional](#) — the Institute's position on the capability facet A measures

— Sources and standards

No external source is cited. Standards named in facet D — ISO 31000 risk management principles, the AACE International total cost management practice, PMBOK, the Scrum Guide, and recognised earned value management guidance — are named as objects of the domain codes and are not reproduced, summarised or represented here; where the report describes them it does so in our own words. Body of Knowledge domain numbers refer to the thirteen domains in [docs/bok/](#). The inter-coder agreement statistics named in §5, Cohen's kappa and Krippendorff's alpha, are standard content-analysis measures described here in our own words.

— Status and version

Founding-stage document · Version 1.0 · draft · Reviewed under PCI governance. PCI makes no claims of accreditation or recognition beyond what is true today.

SAL-05 · SALARY AND SKILLS REPORT

Report template and data tables

The complete shell of the annual report, structurally finished and deliberately empty

VERSION 1.0 · DRAFT
2026-08-04

PROJECT CONTROLS INSTITUTE GLOBAL, INC.
AI proposes. The professional disposes.

— Summary

The full section structure of the Institute's annual salary and skills report: every table with its columns defined and every cell carrying the placeholder [DATA], every chart specified in words, the mandatory methodology and limitations sections written out, and the standing caveats that must appear in every edition. No data has been collected, so no table contains a value. This is the shell into which field data will be dropped, and the rules that govern what may be dropped into it.

— About this document

Document	SAL-05
Series	Salary and Skills Report
Version	1.0
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Unresolved placeholders	6

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Contents

1. What this shell is, and the rule that governs it.....	4
2. Report front matter.....	5
3. Section map	6
4. Section 1 — How to read this report (standing text)	6
5. Section 4 — Who responded.....	7
6. Sections 5 and 6 — Reward tables.....	9
7. Section 7 — Remuneration components.....	10
8. Section 8 — Day-rate engagements.....	12
9. Section 9 — Skills.....	12
10. Sections 10 and 11 — AI use, satisfaction and mobility.....	13
11. Chart specifications.....	15
12. Section 13 — Limitations (standing text).....	16
13. Section 14 — Standing caveats (verbatim block)	16
14. Section 15 — Change log	17
15. Completion rules for the analyst.....	17
16. How this goes wrong.....	17
17. Checklist — before the populated report is released	18
Related	18
Sources and standards.....	18
Status and version	19

Report template and data tables

In one paragraph. This is the full section structure of the Institute's annual salary and skills report: every table with its columns defined and every cell carrying the placeholder `[DATA]`, every chart specified in words, the mandatory methodology and limitations sections written out, and the standing caveats that must appear in every edition. No data has been collected, so no table contains a value. This is the shell into which field data will be dropped, and the rules that govern what may be dropped into it.

Who this is for. The analysts and editors who will produce the report; reviewers checking that the published edition matches the structure that was committed to in advance; and readers who want to inspect the apparatus before there is anything in it to argue about.

— 1. What this shell is, and the rule that governs it

Every table below is complete in its columns and empty in its cells. `[DATA]` marks a value that field data will supply. Each table carries the label **structure only — no data collected**, and that label stays until the survey has been run, analysed and reviewed.

The governing rule: the structure is fixed before the data arrives. An analyst who sees the results first and designs the tables second will — without any dishonest intention — design tables that show what the data happens to say. Fixing the shell in advance means the report's shape cannot be tuned to its findings, and a reader can compare the published edition against this document to check.

Three consequences follow, and they are not negotiable:

- **A table whose cells are suppressed is still published, empty, with the suppression rule named.** Missing cells are the report's most honest content.
- **A table cannot be added after the data is seen** except in the "additional analysis" section (§11), which exists so that genuine discoveries have somewhere to go while remaining visibly separate from the pre-committed structure.
- **A table cannot be removed** because it turned out thin. It is published with its cells suppressed.

— 2. Report front matter

Element	Content
Title	Project Controls Salary and Skills Report <u>[CONFIRM: edition year, reference date and intended publication date]</u>
Publisher	Project Controls Institute Global, Inc.
Edition and version	Edition number, version, date of issue
Citation	<u>[CONFIRM: the citation string readers should use, and whether a persistent identifier is registered]</u>
Licence	<u>[CONFIRM: licence terms for reuse of figures and charts, including whether attribution is required and whether commercial reuse is permitted]</u>
Dataset	<u>[CONFIRM: whether an anonymised dataset is released alongside the report, under what terms, and after what disclosure review]</u>
Accessible formats	<u>[CONFIRM: which formats are produced, and who signs off alt text and table linearisation before release]</u>
Foreword	<u>[CONFIRM: foreword signatory and their governance role]</u>
Contact	hello@projectcontrolsinstitute.org

The cover carries no figure. A headline number on a cover is quoted more often than it is read, and it travels without its denominator.

— 3. Section map

§	Section	Mandatory	Contains
1	How to read this report	Yes	The five questions to ask of any figure; pointer to SAL-06
2	What was measured	Yes	Scope, unit of analysis, reference period, definitions
3	Methodology summary	Yes	Condensed SAL-01 , with the full text as Annex A
4	Who responded	Yes	Sample composition against every characteristic collected
5	Reward by role and level	Yes	The core reward tables
6	Reward by context	Yes	Sector, region, employer type, contract environment
7	Remuneration components	Yes	Base, allowances, variable pay, overtime, retirement, benefits prevalence
8	Day-rate engagements	Yes	Reported separately from salaried reward, never merged
9	Skills	Yes	Held capability, reported requirement, capability gap
10	AI in controls work	Yes	Use, sanction, validation practice, training
11	Satisfaction, mobility and transparency	Yes	Attitudinal findings
12	Additional analysis	No	Anything discovered after the shell was fixed, labelled as such
13	Limitations	Yes	What this report cannot tell you
14	Standing caveats	Yes	Reproduced verbatim from §12 of this document
15	Change log	Yes	Every instrument, taxonomy and method change since the last edition
—	Annexes	Yes	A: methodology · B: instrument · C: role taxonomy · D: skills codebook · E: suppression log · F: full rankings

— 4. Section 1 — How to read this report (standing text)

This section is reproduced in every edition, adjusted only for the edition's specifics.

Every figure in this report is a summary of what a defined group of respondents told us, over a defined period, about a defined component of their pay. It is not a rate, a recommendation or a target.

Five questions to ask of any figure here, or anywhere else:

1. **Who was asked?** Look at the sample composition in §4 before reading any figure.
2. **How many answered this?** Every figure carries its own response count. A figure without one has been quoted incorrectly.
3. **What exactly is being measured?** Base pay, total cash and a day rate are three different quantities. The column heading tells you which.
4. **When?** Every figure refers to the reference period stated in §2.
5. **In what currency and on what basis?** Amounts are converted at a single reference date and are stated gross. Converted figures compare nominal amounts, not living standards.

Where a cell is empty, it is empty because publishing it would have breached one of our disclosure rules — most often because too few people answered. The rule applied is named in the cell and listed in Annex E. We do not fill those gaps with estimates.

Guidance on using figures like these in a real pay conversation is published separately as [SAL-06 – Using market data honestly](#).

— 5. Section 4 — Who responded

Composition is reported before any reward figure, deliberately, so no reader reaches a median before they know who produced it.

Table 1 — Responses by role and level. Structure only — no data collected.

Role	Foundation	Practitioner	Professional	Leader	Total
Planner / scheduler	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]
Cost engineer	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]
Cost controller	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]
Estimator	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]
Risk analyst	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]
Change / commercial controller	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]
Reporting and data analyst	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]
Project controls lead	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]
Project controls manager	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]
Head of project controls	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]
Other / unmatched	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]
Total	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]

Table 2 — Responses by region and country. Structure only — no data collected.

Region	Countries with responses	Responses	Countries meeting the publication threshold
[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]

Table 3 — Responses by employer type and sector. Structure only — no data collected.

Employer type	Responses	Sectors represented	Largest single sector share
[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]

Table 4 — Responses by engagement type and working pattern. Structure only — no data collected.

Engagement type	Full time	Part time	Rotational	Total
Permanent employee	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]
Fixed-term employee	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]
Day-rate contractor	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]
Agency worker	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]
Self-employed	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]
Seconded	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]

Table 5 — Responses by experience band and qualification. Structure only — no data collected.

Experience band	Responses	Highest qualification distribution	Holding any certification
[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]

Table 6 — Item-level completion. Structure only — no data collected. This table exists because skipping is informative: it shows which questions people would not answer.

Question	Shown to	Answered	Answered "prefer not to say"	Skipped
[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]

Table 7 — Data preparation. Structure only — no data collected.

Stage	Records	Reason
Responses received	[DATA]	—
Removed: screened out	[DATA]	Failed eligibility at Q02 or Q05
Removed: duplicates	[DATA]	Same respondent, multiple submissions
Removed: quality rule	[DATA]	Completion time below the pre-set floor, or straight-lined matrices
Items excluded: unit error	[DATA]	Ambiguous period or currency, not correctable
Items excluded: outlier rule	[DATA]	Pre-declared rule in SAL-01 §8
Analysis dataset	[DATA]	—

— 6. Sections 5 and 6 — Reward tables

Every reward table uses the same column grammar, so that a reader who learns to read one can read all of them.

Standard reward table columns.

Column	Definition
Cell	The population the row describes, fully specified
n	Unweighted count of respondents answering this item in this cell
Employer test	Result of the dominance test in SAL-01 §6 rule 3: pass, or the rule that suppressed the cell
Lower quartile	The value below which a quarter of responses fall
Median	The middle value
Upper quartile	The value below which three-quarters of responses fall
Component	Which remuneration component the figures measure
Basis	Currency, gross or net, and period
Note	Suppression rule, combination applied, or other qualification

Table 8 — Base pay by role and level. Structure only — no data collected. Component: base pay only, excluding allowances, variable pay and overtime. Basis: converted to the report's base currency at the reference date, gross, annualised.

Role	Level	n	Employer test	Lower quartile	Median	Upper quartile	Note
Planner / scheduler	Foundation	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]
Planner / scheduler	Practitioner	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]
Planner / scheduler	Professional	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]
Planner / scheduler	Leader	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]
(repeated for each of the ten roles in SAL-03 §3, at each of the four levels)							

Table 9 — Base pay by role group and region. Structure only — no data collected. Combination is permitted only along the hierarchy in [SAL-03](#) §6, and every combined cell says so in the Note column.

Role group	Region	n	Employer test	Lower quartile	Median	Upper quartile	Note
Cost and commercial	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]
Planning and risk	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]
Data and reporting	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]
Controls leadership	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]

Table 10 — Base pay by sector. Structure only — no data collected. One row per sector option at Q15.

Sector	n	Employer test	Lower quartile	Median	Upper quartile	Note
[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]

Table 11 — Base pay by employer type. Structure only — no data collected.

Employer type	n	Employer test	Lower quartile	Median	Upper quartile	Note
[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]

Table 12 — Base pay by experience band, within level. Structure only — no data collected. Reported within level, never across it, because experience and level are not independent.

Level	Experience band	n	Lower quartile	Median	Upper quartile	Note
[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]

Table 13 — Distribution detail. Structure only — no data collected. Published only for cells with 100 or more responses, per SAL-01 §6 rule 2. Cells below that threshold appear here as suppressed, not omitted.

Cell	n	10th percentile	Lower quartile	Median	Upper quartile	90th percentile	Note
[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]

Table 14 — Working pattern and cross-border arrangement. Structure only — no data collected. Rotational, assignment and remote-cross-border respondents are reported separately and never pooled with locally employed respondents in the same cell.

Arrangement	n	Employer test	Lower quartile	Median	Upper quartile	Note
Locally employed and resident	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]
Rotational	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]
International assignment	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]
Remote from another country	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]

7. Section 7 — Remuneration components

Components are reported separately. There is no "total reward" table, and there will not be one until the Institute can construct it from components collected on a consistent basis for the same respondents — at which point it will be published alongside the components, never instead of them.

Table 15 — Prevalence of each component, by role group. Structure only — no data collected. Prevalence is the share of respondents in the cell who report receiving the component at all.

Component	Cost and commercial	Planning and risk	Data and reporting	Controls leadership	n per cell
Fixed allowances (any)	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]
Variable pay scheme	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]
Paid overtime	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]
Employer retirement contribution	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]

Table 16 — Allowance types received. Structure only — no data collected. Prevalence only.

Allowance type	Respondents receiving it	n answering the item	Note
Site or location	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]
Rotation or offshore	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]
Housing	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]
Transport or car	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]
Travel or subsistence	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]
Cost-of-living or hardship	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]
Other fixed allowance	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]

Table 17 — Variable pay, target against paid. Structure only — no data collected. Target and actual are shown in adjacent columns and never averaged together.

Cell	n with a scheme	Target — lower quartile / median / upper quartile	Paid — lower quartile / median / upper quartile	Received nothing	Note
[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]

Table 18 — Non-cash benefits prevalence. Structure only — no data collected. Benefits are never assigned a monetary value; see SAL-02 Q34.

Benefit	Respondents receiving it	n answering the item
[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]

Table 19 — Pay change during the period, by reason. Structure only — no data collected. Reasons and direction only. No magnitude, because the design cannot support one.

Reason	Respondents	n answering the item
No change	[DATA]	[DATA]
Annual review	[DATA]	[DATA]
Promotion	[DATA]	[DATA]
Change of employer	[DATA]	[DATA]
Change of engagement type	[DATA]	[DATA]
Reduction	[DATA]	[DATA]

— 8. Section 8 — Day-rate engagements

A separate section, not a column in the salaried tables. The two are different quantities and the report never converts between them; the reasons are set out for readers in [SAL-06 §6](#).

Table 20 — Day rates by role and level. Structure only — no data collected. Basis: rate received by the respondent, per day, converted at the reference date. Rates charged by an agency to a client are reported separately in Table 21 and never mixed into this one.

Role	Level	n	Employer test	Lower quartile	Median	Upper quartile	Note
[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]

Table 21 — Rates reported as charged to the client. Structure only — no data collected. Reported separately and labelled, because this is a different measurement from what the worker receives.

Role group	n	Lower quartile	Median	Upper quartile	Note
[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]

Table 22 — Days worked and costs borne. Structure only — no data collected. Published adjacent to the rate tables so that no reader takes a rate as an income.

Cell	n	Days worked — banded distribution	Respondents bearing own insurance	Own retirement provision	Own training	Umbrella or accountancy fees
[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]

— 9. Section 9 — Skills

All skills tables use the constructs defined in [SAL-04 §6](#) and name the construct in the table title.

Table 23 — Held capability, by skill and role group. Structure only — no data collected. Construct: held capability (self-assessed against behavioural anchors).

Skill code	Skill	Cost and commercial	Planning and risk	Data and reporting	Controls leadership	n per cell
[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]

Table 24 — Reported requirement, by skill and role group. Structure only — no data collected. Construct: skill explicitly required of the respondent, in a documented form, within the reference period. This table is never captioned or quoted as "demand".

Skill code	Skill	Cost and commercial	Planning and risk	Data and reporting	Controls leadership	n per cell
[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]

Table 25 — Capability gap, computed within respondent. Structure only — no data collected. Construct: explicitly required at the requirement item **and** held at one of the two lowest anchors, for the same respondent.

Skill code	Skill	Respondents with the gap	n answering both items	Note
[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]

Table 26 — Tool categories used, by role group. Structure only — no data collected. Categories only; no product is named in any counted form.

Tool category	Cost and commercial	Planning and risk	Data and reporting	Controls leadership	n per cell
[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]

Table 27 — Free-text coding outcome. Structure only — no data collected. The taxonomy's own error report.

Measure	Value
Free-text segments coded	[DATA]
Segments coded UNC (unmatched)	[DATA]
Share double-coded	[DATA]
Agreement statistic and value	[DATA]
Adjudicated disagreements	[DATA]
Codebook version used	[DATA]

— 10. Sections 10 and 11 — AI use, satisfaction and mobility

Table 28 — AI tool use by task, by role group. Structure only — no data collected. Labelled with the reference period wherever it is reproduced, per [SAL-04](#) §7 rule 6.

Task	Cost and commercial	Planning and risk	Data and reporting	Controls leadership	n per cell
[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]

Table 29 — Sanction and validation practice. Structure only — no data collected. The two questions are reported together because either alone is misleading.

Sanction status	Checks all output	Checks material parts	Reviewed by a colleague	Normal review only	Used as produced	n
Policy exists and permits it	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]
Permitted informally	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]
No policy exists	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]
Prohibited	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]
Don't know	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]

Table 30 — Satisfaction with reward and with role, by level. Structure only — no data collected. Reported as distributions across the five scale points, never as a single mean score.

Level	Reward — distribution across five points	Role — distribution across five points	n
[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]

Table 31 — Mobility intention and stated reasons. Structure only — no data collected.

Cell	n	Distribution across likelihood points	Reasons selected (multi-select, sums above the total)
[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]

Table 32 — Pay transparency arrangement at the employer. Structure only — no data collected. Reported without any statement that one arrangement is preferable or required; transparency law differs by jurisdiction and the report takes no position on any jurisdiction's.

Arrangement	Respondents	n
[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]

Table 33 — Cross-cycle comparison eligibility. Structure only — no data collected. Completed before any comparison is written, and published whether or not any comparison passed.

Cell	n this cycle	n prior cycle	Question wording unchanged	Code or definition unchanged	Comparison permitted
[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]

11. Chart specifications

Charts are specified in words here so that the visual design cannot quietly change what the data says. Every chart carries its response count in the subtitle — not the caption, not a footnote — and every chart respects the suppression rules; a suppressed cell is drawn as an explicit gap with a label, never interpolated, never omitted so that the axis closes over it.

Chart	Question it answers	Mark and encoding	Axis rules	Must not
C1 Sample composition	Who responded	Stacked horizontal bars, one bar per role, segments by level	Count axis from zero	Use a pie chart; imply the sample is the profession
C2 Base pay distribution by level	How spread out is pay within a level	Box plot per level: quartiles as the box, whiskers to the tenth and ninetieth percentiles where n permits	Value axis from zero; identical scale across panels	Draw whiskers where the distribution-detail threshold is not met
C3 Base pay by role group	How role groups compare	Grouped box plots, one panel per region meeting the threshold	Shared scale across panels	Rank groups by median without showing overlap
C4 Component prevalence	Which components a cell actually receives	Horizontal bars, one per component	Share axis from zero to whole	Stack components as though they sum to a total reward
C5 Day rate against days worked	Why a rate is not an income	Two adjacent distributions, rate and days, on separate axes	Separate panels, never a dual axis	Multiply one by the other, in the chart or in the caption
C6 Skills — required against held	Where the gaps are	Paired bars per skill, requirement and capability adjacent	Common share axis	Draw a connecting line implying a per-person gap; the gap has its own chart
C7 Capability gap	The within-respondent gap	Horizontal bars, ordered, with tied ranks shown as a shared band	Share axis from zero	Truncate the axis; show only the top of the ranking
C8 AI use by sanction status	Whether use is governed	Small multiples, one panel per sanction status	Identical scale across panels	Combine panels into a single total that hides the governance split
C9 Satisfaction distribution	How opinion is spread	Diverging stacked bars centred between the middle points	Symmetric about the centre	Reduce the distribution to a mean score

Accessibility rules for every chart. No meaning is carried by colour alone — every encoding is also carried by position, pattern or a direct label. Each chart has alt text describing what it shows and what the reader should take from it, and each has an accompanying table so that the same content is available linearly.

Two prohibitions that apply to all charts. No trend line is drawn through fewer than three comparable cycles. No chart places pay against any respondent characteristic in a way that implies causation, because a cross-sectional survey cannot support a causal claim in either direction.

— 12. Section 13 — Limitations (standing text)

Reproduced in every edition, extended where an edition has a specific additional limitation.

This is a volunteer sample. Respondents chose to take part. It is not a random sample of project controls professionals, and no statistical technique in this report converts it into one. Figures describe the people who answered.

Composition drives everything. Read §4 before any figure. A cell that is mostly one region, one sector or one employer describes that region, sector or employer.

Self-report. Pay, skills and level are as reported by respondents. We validate internal consistency and correct unambiguous unit errors; we cannot verify a payslip.

Cross-sectional. This report describes one period. It cannot establish that anything causes anything else — not experience, not sector, not certification, not skills.

Currency conversion compares nominal amounts. It says nothing about purchasing power, tax, social contributions or what any of it buys where the respondent lives.

Jurisdictions differ. Employment law, tax treatment, mandatory retirement provision, benefit norms and pay-transparency requirements vary by country. Nothing here should be read as describing any jurisdiction's rules.

Suppression is not absence. An empty cell means we would not publish it, not that nobody works in that role. Annex E lists every suppression and the rule applied.

The gaps are where the need is greatest. Smaller markets and specialist roles are the hardest to report and the most poorly served by existing data. We would rather leave the cell empty than fill it with something we cannot defend.

— 13. Section 14 — Standing caveats (verbatim block)

Reproduced without alteration in every edition, in the report, in the executive summary, and in any extract or slide deck the Institute publishes from it.

What this report is. A summary of what a self-selected group of project controls professionals told us about their roles, their pay and their skills, over one defined period, under the published methodology.

What it is not. It is not a rate card, a pay recommendation, a benchmark for setting an individual's pay, or a forecast. It does not state what any role "should" pay.

On certification and pay. Nothing in this report should be read as a claim that holding any certification — including the Institute's own — produces a pay outcome. PCI makes no claim of guaranteed employment or salary outcomes. Where certification status appears in this report it is a respondent characteristic, and a cross-sectional survey cannot establish causation.

On the Institute's status. PCI's certifications are developed with reference to ISO/IEC 17024 personnel-certification principles. PCI is not accredited by any ISO/IEC 17024 accreditation body.

On independence. No sponsor, employer, recruitment business or vendor saw these results before publication, chose which analyses were published, or had any role in the methodology.

On correction. If a figure here is wrong, we will correct it publicly, on the same channels that carried it, with a dated note in this document.

— 14. Section 15 — Change log

Table 34 — Changes since the previous edition. Structure only — no data collected. Completed for every edition including the first, where it records the baseline.

Item changed	Type	Previous	Current	Effect on comparability
[DATA]	Instrument wording / option set / routing / taxonomy / codebook / method / suppression rule	[DATA]	[DATA]	[DATA]

A change with an effect on comparability breaks that series. The break is stated in the affected table, not only here.

— 15. Completion rules for the analyst

1. Populate the shell in the order the sections appear. Composition tables are completed and reviewed before any reward table is populated.
2. Run the suppression tests before formatting anything. A suppressed cell keeps its row.
3. Never delete a row or column because it is empty.
4. Never add a table outside §12 (additional analysis).
5. Every figure carries its own n. If a figure cannot be given an n, it cannot be published.
6. Write the caption before the number is in the cell, so the caption describes the measurement rather than the result.
7. Reproduce §12 and §13 of the report verbatim. They are not edited for tone, length or edition.
8. Complete Table 33 before writing any sentence comparing this cycle with the last.
9. Hand the populated draft to a reviewer who has not seen the data, together with this document, and ask them to find any structural difference.

— 16. How this goes wrong

A headline appears on the cover. The single number that summarises nothing becomes the thing everyone quotes. The rule in §2 exists to prevent it, and it will be argued about every year.

Empty tables are quietly dropped. The report looks tidier and the reader loses the most informative content in it — the record of what could not be said.

Components are summed into total reward because a reader asked for one number. The result is a total built from different components for different respondents, which is the exact error §7 exists to prevent.

A day rate is annualised. Someone multiplies a rate by a plausible number of days and prints it beside a salary. Chart C5's prohibition is written down because this will be proposed.

The chart improves the finding. An axis is truncated to make a difference visible, or a suppressed category is dropped so the bars sit neatly. Both are misrepresentations, and both look like design decisions.

The report is careful and the promotion is not. The caveats are in the document, and the post says "the most in-demand skill in project controls". The standing caveats bind every extract for this reason.

— 17. Checklist — before the populated report is released

- [] Structure matches this document; any difference is deliberate, recorded and justified
 - [] Composition tables completed and reviewed before any reward figure was populated
 - [] Every cell either contains a figure with an n, or names the suppression rule applied
 - [] No table added outside the additional-analysis section; no table removed
 - [] No total-reward figure constructed from components collected inconsistently
 - [] Day rates and salaries reported separately, with no conversion anywhere in text or chart
 - [] Table 33 completed before any cross-cycle statement was written
 - [] Standing caveats reproduced verbatim, including in the summary and any slide extract
 - [] Limitations section present, complete and unedited except for additions
 - [] Annexes A–F all present, including the suppression log and the full rankings
 - [] Every chart carries its n in the subtitle, and its alt text and companion table
 - [] No colour-only encoding; every chart readable in greyscale
 - [] No claim of causation anywhere, including in the foreword
 - [] No accreditation, endorsement or pay-outcome claim anywhere, including in the promotional copy
-

— Related

- [SAL-01 – Salary and skills report – framework and methodology](#) — the rules that decide what may enter these cells
- [SAL-02 – The survey instrument](#) — the questions each table draws from, by number
- [SAL-03 – Role taxonomy and levelling](#) — the row labels and the permitted aggregation hierarchy
- [SAL-04 – The skills demand taxonomy](#) — the constructs and vocabulary behind the skills tables
- [SAL-06 – Using market data honestly](#) — the reader-facing companion referenced in the report's own §1

— Sources and standards

No external source is cited, and no cell in this document contains a value. The structure draws on the Institute's own methodology ([SAL-01](#)), instrument ([SAL-02](#)), taxonomy ([SAL-03](#)) and skills vocabulary ([SAL-04](#)), and on the accreditation and independence wording fixed in [00-framework/CANONICAL-FACTS.md](#) §2.1. Currency conversion follows the source and reference date fixed under [SAL-01](#) §9.

— Status and version

Founding-stage document · Version 1.0 · draft · Reviewed under PCI governance. PCI makes no claims of accreditation or recognition beyond what is true today.

SAL-06 · SALARY AND SKILLS REPORT

Using market data honestly

How to read a pay figure, and how to use one without
misrepresenting it

VERSION 1.0 · DRAFT

2026-08-04

PROJECT CONTROLS INSTITUTE GLOBAL, INC.

AI proposes. The professional disposes.

— Summary

How to read published pay and skills data without being misled by it: what a median does and does not tell you, why a range without a sample size is not information, why advertised pay is a different quantity from paid pay, how to benchmark a role rather than a title, why a day rate cannot be converted into a salary, and how to bring market data into a pay conversation in a way that survives someone checking it.

— About this document

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Contents

1. What a pay figure actually is	4
2. How to read a median	4
3. Why a range without a sample size is not information	5
4. Advertised is not paid	6
5. Benchmark the role, not the title	6
6. Compare like with like — components, and the day-rate trap	7
7. Using market data in a pay conversation	7
8. Reading a skills claim	8
9. How this goes wrong	8
10. Checklist — before you quote a pay figure	9
Related	9
Sources and standards	10
Status and version	10

Using market data honestly

In one paragraph. This document explains how to read published pay and skills data without being misled by it: what a median does and does not tell you, why a range without a sample size is not information, why advertised pay is a different quantity from paid pay, how to benchmark a role rather than a title, why a day rate cannot be converted into a salary, and how to bring market data into a pay conversation in a way that survives someone checking it.

Who this is for. Practitioners preparing for a pay or promotion conversation; managers and heads of function who have to answer "what should this role pay?"; and anyone about to quote a figure from a salary guide in public.

— 1. What a pay figure actually is

Every published pay figure is the answer to a question that has been asked of some people, at some time, about some component of their pay, and then summarised. Five things are therefore built into it before anyone reads it: **who was asked, how many answered, what exactly was measured, when, and on what basis** — currency, gross or net, and over what period.

Change any one of those and the figure changes, often substantially, without the label changing at all. A figure for "cost engineers" drawn mostly from contractor organisations in one region, measuring base pay only, is a different quantity from a figure with the same label drawn mostly from client organisations across several regions, measuring total cash. Both are honest. Neither is comparable with the other. And neither is comparable with your situation until you have established which one you resemble.

This is not a counsel of despair about market data. It is the difference between using a figure as evidence and using it as a slogan.

— 2. How to read a median

A median is a position, not a typical value. Sort every response from lowest to highest; the median is the one in the middle. If there are eleven responses, it is the sixth. That is the whole definition, and it explains both its strength and its limits.

Why a median rather than a mean. The mean adds everything up and divides. Pay distributions are not symmetric — they have a long upper tail, because a small number of people in any group are paid far above the rest and nobody is paid far below zero. A handful of very high responses pulls a mean upwards until it sits above most of the people it claims to describe. The median does not move when the top response gets larger; only its position matters. When you see a mean quoted for pay, the first question is why the median was not.

What a median does not tell you. Four things, and each of them matters more than the median itself in most real decisions.

- **It says nothing about spread.** Two groups can share a median while one is tightly clustered and the other spans an enormous range. Half the people in a group are below its median by definition, and some of them are a long way below.
- **It says nothing about you.** The median is a property of a distribution, not a claim about any individual in it. "I am below the median" is not evidence of underpayment; it is evidence of being in the lower half, which half of everyone is.
- **It says nothing about direction.** A median is a snapshot. It contains no information about where pay is heading.
- **It says nothing about the shape of the tails.** Whether the upper half is a gentle slope or a cliff changes what a realistic ambition looks like, and the median is silent on it.

Which is why quartiles matter more. The lower quartile is the value a quarter of responses fall below; the upper quartile is the value three-quarters fall below. The distance between them — the interquartile range — is the honest description of where the middle half of a group sits, and it is the number to look for. A source that publishes a median without quartiles has told you where the middle is while withholding how wide it is.

And percentiles are just positions too. The ninetieth percentile is the value ninety per cent of responses fall below. It is not "what good people earn". It is a position in a particular distribution, computed from whoever happened to answer, and in a small sample it is one or two people.

— 3. Why a range without a sample size is not information

A range is two numbers. Without the count behind it, you cannot tell whether it summarises a hundred careers or four.

Worse, "range" is used for two entirely different things and sources rarely say which. A **minimum to maximum** range is defined by its two most extreme responses — a single unusual answer sets one end of it, which is why it widens as the sample grows. An **interquartile range** describes the middle half and is stable. The first is nearly useless for decisions; the second is what you want. They are printed identically.

Five questions to ask of any published figure, in order:

1. **Who was asked, and how were they found?** A volunteer sample recruited through one network is a description of that network.
2. **How many answered this specific figure?** Not the survey's headline total — the count behind the cell you are reading. Response counts fall sharply on pay questions.
3. **What exactly is being measured?** Base pay, total cash, or a rate. If the source does not say, treat the figure as unusable rather than as base pay.
4. **When?** A figure with no reference period is undated evidence.
5. **In what currency, and gross or net?** Converted figures compare nominal amounts. They say nothing about what the money buys, and nothing about tax or mandatory contributions, which differ by country.

A source that cannot answer all five is not necessarily wrong. It is unverifiable, which for the purpose of a decision amounts to the same thing.

— 4. Advertised is not paid

Advertised pay and paid pay are different quantities, and treating them as one is the most common error in this area.

An advertisement is a market offer, written to attract applicants, before any negotiation, before anyone has been assessed, and often before the employer has decided what they will actually pay the person they choose. Whether a range is published at all depends on where the role sits: some jurisdictions require pay information in advertisements and others do not, so the presence, absence and width of an advertised range tells you as much about local law and local convention as about the employer's intent. Never assume the rule that applies where you are applies anywhere else.

Three specific ways advertised data misleads:

- **Selection.** Roles that are hard to fill are advertised repeatedly and prominently; roles filled internally or through networks are never advertised at all. Scraped advertisement data over-represents hard-to-fill and high-turnover roles by construction.
- **The top of the range.** An advertised range's upper end is frequently reserved for a candidate who exceeds the specification, and often goes unpaid. Quoting it as "the market rate" quotes an aspiration.
- **Component ambiguity.** Advertisements mix base, total package, and rates, and rarely say which. Two advertisements for the same job can differ by everything and by nothing.

Advertisement data is genuinely useful for one thing: seeing what employers say they want, in their own words, at scale. That is a requirements signal, not a pay measurement. Used for the first, it is evidence. Presented as the second, it is research theatre.

— 5. Benchmark the role, not the title

Job titles are the worst available classification variable and the most commonly used one. A "senior planner" at one employer integrates cost, schedule and risk across a programme; at the employer next door the same title updates one contractor's schedule. Comparing your pay to a figure attached to your title compares you to whoever else shares the word.

Benchmark instead in three steps.

Decompose the job. Write down what you are accountable for, what artefacts you own, and what decisions are made on your judgement without anyone re-doing them. That is the role.

Level it on behaviour. Autonomy, the scope you own, what you are trusted to decide when the data does not settle it, whose reported numbers you are accountable for, who you influence, and whether you develop method and people. [SAL-03](#) sets out the rubric and its decision rules, including the one people find hardest: you cannot be levelled above the scope you actually own, however senior your influence feels.

Match to the definition, then read the figure. Only after you know which role and level you occupy is a published figure about you rather than about a word.

Two honest complications. First, the same role genuinely pays differently by sector, employer type, contracting model and location, so a match on role and level is a start and not a conclusion. Second, if your job does not fit any published definition — which happens most in small teams,

where one person does four roles — the right response is to say so, and to benchmark the largest component of your time rather than pretending to a clean match.

— 6. Compare like with like — components, and the day-rate trap

Pay is not one number. A comparison is only valid when both sides measure the same components.

Components. Base pay, fixed allowances (site, rotation, housing, transport), variable pay — which divides into what you are targeted at and what you were actually paid — overtime where it exists, employer retirement contribution, and non-cash benefits. Two people with identical base pay can have materially different total positions, and neither of them is being deceptive.

Benefits resist valuation, so do not fake one. Assigning money to healthcare cover, additional leave or a car requires assumptions about local cost and tax treatment that vary by country. Treat benefits as a list you compare item by item, not as a number you add on.

Day rates and salaries are not convertible. This is worth stating carefully, because the conversion is attempted constantly. A contractor's annualised income is not the rate multiplied by a full year:

$$\text{annual income} = \text{daily rate} \times \text{chargeable days worked} - \text{costs borne}$$

Chargeable days are reduced by every day not on assignment: gaps between contracts, unpaid leave, sickness, notice periods and non-chargeable time. Costs borne include insurance, retirement provision the employer does not fund, own training, own equipment, and accountancy or umbrella fees. There is also a risk term that never appears in the arithmetic — the possibility of the assignment ending at short notice — and an employment-status dimension that differs by jurisdiction and which nobody should assume transfers across borders.

There is no general multiplier between a rate and a salary. Anyone who offers you one is offering you an assumption about utilisation, costs and risk appetite, wearing the costume of a calculation. Compare rates with rates and salaries with salaries.

— 7. Using market data in a pay conversation

Market data belongs in a pay conversation as context for your case, never as the case itself. A figure tells your employer what other people are paid; it says nothing about what you have done. The conversations that go well are the ones where the data frames a discussion the evidence about your own work carries.

What to bring.

- The role and level you have matched yourself to, with the reasoning — not the title.
- The specific figure, its source, its reference period, its response count and what component it measures. Being able to say what the number is puts you in a stronger position than the number itself does.
- Evidence about you: what you own, what you decide, what changed because of your work, what you now do that you did not do a year ago.
- An awareness of what the data cannot support, stated by you before it is pointed out to you. This costs nothing and buys a great deal of credibility.

What to avoid.

- **Quoting the upper quartile as "the market".** It is the level a quarter of responses sit above. Using it as the central figure is a misrepresentation, and a manager with the same report in front of them will see it immediately.
- **Quoting a figure whose source you cannot describe.** If you cannot answer the five questions in §3 about it, do not put it on the table.
- **Comparing your base to someone else's total.** The single most common failure in these conversations.
- **Treating your position below a median as an argument in itself.** Half of any group is below its median.
- **Claiming a certification will produce an increase.** No professional body can promise a pay outcome, and the Institute makes no such claim about its own credentials. What a credential evidences is assessed competence against a published standard; what that is worth in a particular role, at a particular employer, is a separate question with its own evidence.
- **Presenting one country's pay-transparency or employment rules as though they applied here.** They may not.

When the data is thin — which, for most specific roles in most specific places, it will be.

Say so. "There is no reliable published figure for this role in this market; here is the nearest defensible comparison and here is why it is not exact" is a stronger position than a confident figure that collapses under one question. It also happens to be true, which is the more durable advantage.

— 8. Reading a skills claim

The same discipline applies to skills findings, where the vocabulary is looser and the temptation greater.

"The most in-demand skill in project controls" is almost always one of three much narrower things: what a self-selected group of respondents said was asked of them; what appeared most often in a set of scraped advertisements; or what the publisher's consultants have noticed lately. Each is a real observation. None of them is demand in any economic sense, which would require vacancies, time-to-fill and wage movement.

Ask which construct is being reported: what people were asked for, what people can do, or the gap between the two for the same person. If the source does not distinguish them, it has not measured any of them carefully. And treat any statement about AI skills as dated from the moment it is published — that part of the picture moves faster than annual reporting can follow, which is a reason to check the reference period rather than a reason to ignore the finding.

— 9. How this goes wrong

The figure outlives its caveats. A number is quoted from a report into a slide, from the slide into a conversation, and by the third hop the sample size, the component and the year are gone. Everything after that is confident and unfounded.

Both sides quote different halves of the same table. The employee brings the upper quartile; the employer brings the lower. Neither is lying and the conversation is now about statistics rather than about the work.

The self-selected comparator. You compare yourself to the two colleagues who talk about pay. They are not a sample; they are the people who talk about pay, which is a specific and unrepresentative trait.

Anchoring on a rate. A contractor's day rate is heard, mentally multiplied by a working year, and used as the standard of comparison. \$6 exists for this, and it will still happen.

Level inflation in the benchmarking. You match yourself against the level you are working towards rather than the one you occupy, and the comparison is off by a level before any figure is read.

Using a hole as evidence. A report suppresses a cell for having too few responses, and someone infers that the role is rare, or undervalued, or in decline. An empty cell means the data was too thin to publish. It means nothing else.

— 10. Checklist — before you quote a pay figure

- [] I can name the source, its publisher and its reference period
 - [] I know how many responses are behind this specific figure
 - [] I know exactly which component it measures — base, total cash, or a rate
 - [] I know the currency and whether it is gross or net
 - [] I have matched my role and level by accountability, not by title
 - [] I am quoting a central measure, not the top of the distribution
 - [] I am comparing the same components on both sides
 - [] I have not converted a day rate into a salary or a salary into a day rate
 - [] I can state what this figure cannot tell anyone, before I am asked
 - [] I am not attaching a pay outcome to a qualification, mine or anyone else's
 - [] I am not assuming any jurisdiction's employment or pay-transparency rules apply elsewhere
 - [] My case rests on evidence about my work; the figure is context, not the argument
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The practitioners who do well in these conversations are not the ones with the best number. They are the ones who can say precisely what their number means, and precisely where it stops — which is the same discipline that makes a forecast credible, applied to a different subject.

— Related

- [SAL-01 – Salary and skills report – framework and methodology](#) — how the Institute's own figures will be produced, and the rules that constrain them
 - [SAL-03 – Role taxonomy and levelling](#) — the role definitions and levelling rubric to benchmark against
 - [SAL-05 – Report template and data tables](#) — the report's structure, including what every empty cell means
 - [CAR-01 – The project controls career roadmap](#) — where a role sits in a career, as distinct from what it pays
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- [ETH-03 – Reporting numbers under pressure – a casebook](#) — the same discipline applied to project reporting

— Sources and standards

No external source is cited, and no pay figure appears in this document. The statistical concepts described — median, quartile, interquartile range, percentile, and the effect of a skewed distribution on a mean — are standard and are explained here in our own words. The role and levelling references are to [SAL-03](#); the Institute's position on certification and pay outcomes is the wording fixed in [00-framework/CANONICAL-FACTS.md](#) §2.1.

— Status and version

Founding-stage document · Version 1.0 · draft · Reviewed under PCI governance. PCI makes no claims of accreditation or recognition beyond what is true today.